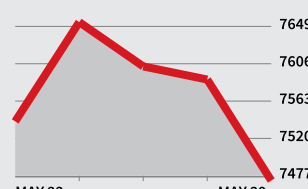


SENSEX 74775.74 (-1092.06)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23547.75	-359.40
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.10	-0.29
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.00	-0.69
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	155836.00	+389
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	263350.00	+2433

MARKET DISTORTION.

Chinese dumping a concern for the air compressor and manufacturing sector, says Elgi Equipments MD Jairam Varadaraj **p2**



AUTO FOCUS.

Mercedes CLA 250+ impresses with style, performance, range and premium appeal **p4**

QUICKLY.

GROWTH POTENTIAL

Trade deal with India likely in months: US envoy Gor



New Delhi: The Donald Trump administration is identifying new global centres of power and is expanding its partnership with India, recognising the country's immense growth potential, US Ambassador Sergio Gor stated on Friday. Speaking at an event at IIT-Delhi, Gor expressed optimism that an interim India-US trade deal could be finalised in the "coming weeks and months". **p3**

TESTING TROUBLE

Supreme Court slams NTA for NEET-UG paper leak

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday said the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak had left students and families traumatised with years of hard work gone to waste, even as the Centre said the Prime Minister is "personally monitoring" the situation. The Bench asked why the National Testing Agency (NTA) repeats its mistakes when the UPSC had so far made none. **p11**

India faces its driest year since 2015; rains seen at 90% of LPA

LOST VIGOUR. South-West monsoon runs into a western disturbance, delaying its onset

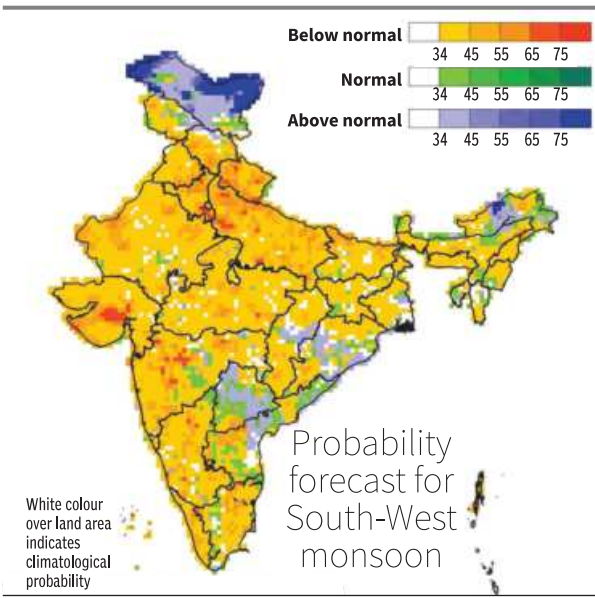
Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Friday scaled down its projection for the South-West monsoon to 90 per cent of the Long-Period Average (below-normal rainfall), leaving the country facing its driest weather in 11 years.

The rainfall, taking into account the Long-Period Average (LPA) or the average rain since 1971, will likely be the lowest since 2015. It could leave most parts of the country dry.

In 2015, it was 86 per cent of the LPA, while in 2014, it was 88 per cent of the LPA. In 1991, the IMD forecast monsoon rain at 90 per cent of the LPA. In 2023, the monsoon was 92 per cent LPA, which resulted in over a third of the country experiencing long dry periods and drought.

MAY SET IN NEXT WEEK
The IMD downward revision of the April forecast, of 92 per cent of the LPA, comes as the monsoon has run into an incoming western disturbance and lost its vigour. The emer-



gence of El Nino next month is seen as the main reason.

Releasing the second stage monsoon forecast for 2026, IMD Director-General M Mohapatra said the South-West monsoon, which accounts for over 75 per cent of the country's annual rainfall, is likely to break over the Kerala coast next week.

Initially, the IMD had predicted the monsoon to set in

on May 26 before it stumbled. The European

Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts (ECMWF) expects a trough developing from coastal Karnataka northwards to be sufficient to trigger moderate to heavy rainfall over central Kerala.

The IMD's numerical model guidance continues to indicate that the monsoon

onset may be delayed until June 4-5. From June 8 to 15, the monsoon may lose some of its early momentum, with rainfall retreating largely to coastal Kerala and coastal Karnataka.

CORE AREA TO BE HIT

The IMD's projection has an error margin of ± 4 per cent.

Mohapatra said the South, Central and North-West regions will have below normal rain, while the East and North-East meteorological sub-divisions may have normal precipitation (94-106 per cent of the LPA) in the June-September monsoon season.

Normal to above normal rainfall is likely in some areas of the North-West and Eastern parts of the southern peninsula and adjoining areas of East-Central India.

The IMD Director-General said that in the monsoon core zone, consisting of most of the rainfed agriculture areas of Central India, it is likely to be below normal, or less than 94 per cent of the LPA.

With inputs from Vinson Kurian in Thiruvananthapuram

India's FY27 growth outlook remains positive, but beware headwinds: RBI

Our Bureau
Mumbai

India's growth outlook for FY27 remains positive, supported by strong macroeconomic fundamentals, though the West Asia conflict and the attendant risks could pose headwinds to growth and inflation in the short run, according to the RBI's Annual Report for FY26.

The report noted that the domestic economy is expected to remain resilient despite a challenging external environment, with the growth prospects backed by strong macroeconomic fundamentals, including robust domestic demand, relatively lower dependence on exports as a growth driver and a stable policy environment.

The risks that the report flagged include elevated energy prices, supply chain disruptions, financial market volatility, uncertainty surrounding global trade policies and weather-related disruptions.

GROWTH MOMENTUM

The report noted that healthy corporate and bank balance sheets, the government's continued thrust on capital expenditure and the implementation of trade agreements with key part-



The West Asia conflict poses growth and inflation risks, says the RBI Annual Report **p11**

ners are expected to sustain investment and growth momentum. Nevertheless, in a highly uncertain global environment, continuous assessment of the evolving developments is warranted to frame the appropriate policy response.

Real GDP growth for 2026-27 is projected at 6.9 per cent with risks tilted to the downside. This projection takes into account factors such as implementation of various trade agreements, rising irrigation intensity and improved crop management practices, efforts in ensuring adequate availability of fertilizer and other key inputs, and focused policy push on seven strategic and frontier sectors.

It also assumes that the adverse impact of the West Asia conflict would remain contained in the near term.

The report said that in FY27, inflation is likely to remain aligned with the (4 per cent) target on the back of adequate foodgrain stocks, sufficient reservoir levels and stable agricultural prospects despite possible El Nino conditions and above-normal summer temperatures.

However, upside risks to inflation may come from other factors, such as a spike in global fuel and commodity prices amid geopolitical tensions, potential spillovers to input and wage costs, and volatility in the exchange rate. Considering all these factors, retail (CPI) inflation for FY27 is projected at 4.6 per cent with risks tilted to the upside.

SUFFICIENT BUFFER

The report expects the banking system to remain resilient, supported by regulatory reforms, stable credit growth and adequate capital buffers.

However, geopolitical tensions and supply chain disruptions may pose near-term risks to corporate earnings and the performance of loan portfolios. "Elevated sovereign yields may also exert pressure on financial institutions' investment portfolios."

More reports on **p5**

Flight cancellations, lower yield, pricier fuel drag IndiGo to a loss of ₹2,537 crore in Q4

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Sharp foreign exchange losses, operational disruptions, lower yields and rising fuel costs weighed on the financial performance of InterGlobe Aviation, the parent company of IndiGo, during the fourth quarter of FY26. The airline reported a consolidated net loss of ₹2,536.9 crore for the quarter, compared to a net profit of ₹3,067.5 crore in the corresponding period last year. It said continuing disruptions linked to the West Asia conflict and operational pressures during the quarter materially impacted profitability.

InterGlobe Aviation MD Rahul Bhatia said: "FY26 was marked by an exceptionally

Q4 performance (in ₹ crore)

	Q4FY25	Q4FY26	y-o-y (%)
Net profit/loss	3,067.5	-2,536.9	-182.7
Revenue from operations	22,151.9	22,438.4	1.3
Total income	23,097.5	23,830.7	3.2
Passengers (million)	31.9	31.6	-1.1

challenging operating environment, which materially impacted our profitability. Despite these conditions, the underlying performance of the business remained resilient."

TRAFFIC SLOWDOWN

"During the year, our capacity grew by 9.5 per cent, and total income increased by over 6 per cent. Excluding the impact of foreign exchange and exceptional items, IndiGo delivered a profit of ₹75 billion," he ad-

ded. Passenger traffic during the quarter declined 1.1 per cent to 31.6 million, while the load factor dropped by 1.7 percentage points to 85.8 per cent.

Similarly, the yield declined 2.2 per cent to ₹5.20, reflecting pressure on passenger revenues. However, consolidated revenue from operations rose 1.3 per cent to ₹22,438.4 crore (₹22,151.9 crore). Total income increased 3.2 per cent to ₹23,830.7 crore from ₹23,097.5 crore.

EXPENSES SURGE

Total expenses surged 30.1 per cent to ₹25,932.5 crore, largely due to higher non-fuel costs, labour-related provisioning, and foreign exchange impact.

The airline also cited ₹249.9 crore as exceptional items during the quarter, following incremental provisions linked to the new Labour Codes.

InterGlobe Aviation said excluding the impact of forex fluctuations and exceptional items, it would have reported a net profit of ₹1,920.6 crore for the quarter.

On a full-year basis, InterGlobe Aviation reported a consolidated net loss of ₹2,393.6 crore for FY26, compared to a net profit of ₹7,258.4 crore in FY25.

Also read **p9**

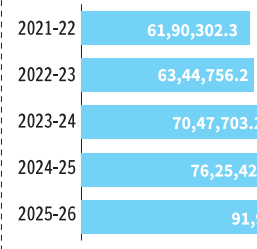
In expansionary mode

The Reserve Bank of India's balance sheet expanded by 20.6 per cent in FY26 to ₹91.97 lakh crore, driven mainly by a 63.8 per cent surge in the valuation of gold holdings amid rising global gold prices, and a 44.9 per cent increase in domestic investments to ₹22.59 lakh crore due to large-scale open market operations. RBI's income also strengthened, supported by higher interest earnings from rupee and foreign securities and foreign exchange gains, which rose to ₹1.69 lakh crore. The contingency fund increased to ₹5.68 lakh crore, though its share of the balance sheet fell to 6.5 per cent from 7.5 per cent.

RBI's balance sheet grew by 20 per cent in FY26

■ Total assets/liabilities (in ₹ cr)

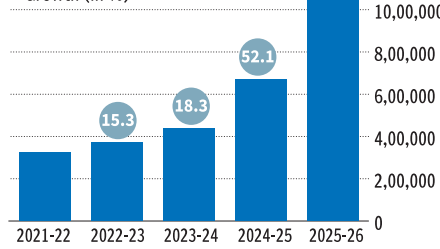
● Growth (in %)



Led by 64% rise in value of gold assets of RBI...

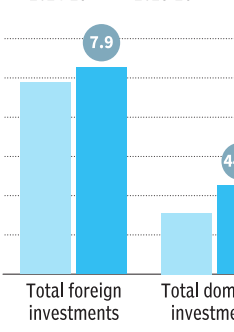
■ Gold assets (in ₹ cr)

● Growth (in %)



...And increase in domestic investments

■ 2024-25 ■ 2025-26 ● Change

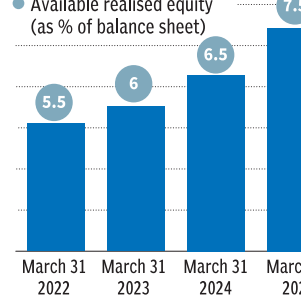


Source: RBI

Lower transfer to contingency buffer as % of balance sheet

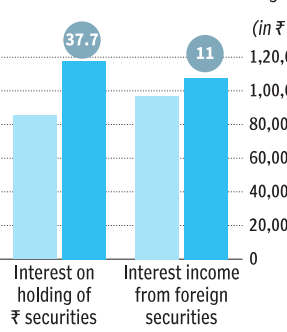
■ Balance in contingency fund (in ₹ cr)

● Available realised equity (as % of balance sheet)



Income boosted by higher interest

■ 2024-25 ■ 2025-26 ● Change



Compiled by Sourashis Banerjee

In affordability push, Tesla cuts new Model Y price by ₹9 lakh

EV giant shelves 2 models; new variant takes on BYD Sealion 7, Hyundai Ioniq 5, BMW iX1

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Tesla has slashed the entry price of its India portfolio by nearly ₹9 lakh and repositioned the Model Y directly into India's crowded ₹45-55 lakh premium EV battleground, with the newly launched Model Y Premium Rear-Wheel Drive priced ₹50.89 lakh (ex-showroom) taking on rivals such as the BYD Sealion 7, Hyundai Ioniq 5 and BMW iX1 after a slower-than-expected start in the country.

TARIFF REALITY

The launch also marks a major rejig of Tesla's India lineup, with the company discontinuing the ₹59.89 lakh Model Y RWD and the ₹67.89 lakh Long Range RWD variants as it shifts toward a lower-cost, more market-aligned configura-



PRODUCT REJIG. The price reduction has largely been achieved through battery and feature repackaging **TESLA INDIA**

tion strategy.

Importantly, the nearly ₹9 lakh reduction has no connection with India's new EV manufacturing policy or any tariff concessions under the proposed India-US trade framework, as Tesla has not signed up for the Centre's EV manufacturing scheme and continues to import vehicles as completely built-up units (CBUs), attracting duty of 70-110 per cent.

The lower pricing re-

flects a broader inventory and portfolio restructuring after weaker-than-expected demand. Industry estimates suggest Tesla has sold fewer than 350 vehicles in India since launch, with bookings crossing only around 600 units despite years of anticipation around the brand's arrival.

COST OPTIMISATION

The price reduction has largely been achieved through battery and feature

repackaging. The new Model Y Premium RWD uses a smaller 60-62 kWh lithium iron phosphate (LFP) battery pack, replacing the costlier long-range nickel manganese cobalt (NMC) setup offered earlier.

The discontinued Long Range RWD variant carried a substantially larger 75-79 kWh NMC battery pack, which sharply increased the vehicle's CIF (cost-insurance-freight) value — the base on which India's import duties are calculated.

By shifting to a smaller LFP battery configuration, Tesla has lowered the imported value of the vehicle, helping reduce the final retail price while retaining the driving range. Despite the lower pricing, the new variant adds upgraded cabin and infotainment features.

'Zero Coupon Zero Principal' bonds open new CSR window for India Inc, will deepen SSE

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

In a move aimed at deepening India's nascent Social Stock Exchange (SSE) ecosystem, the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) has allowed companies to deploy a portion of their Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) spending through 'Zero Coupon Zero Principal' (ZCZP) instruments. The decision comes nearly four years after ZCZP instruments were formally recognised as securities under the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, 1956.

A notification issued by the MCA allows companies to channel up to 10 per cent of their annual CSR expenditure through ZCZP instruments. But the Rules clarify that companies subscribing to such instruments will not be allowed to undertake impact assessments of projects financed through them.



Firms can channel up to 10% of their annual CSR expenditure through ZCZP instruments

A ZCZP instrument carries neither interest payments nor requires the repayment of principal, effectively making it a philanthropic funding mechanism routed through a market framework.

Under Section 135 of the Companies Act, firms with a net worth of ₹500 crore or more, turnover of ₹1,000 crore or more or net profit of at least ₹5 crore in the immediately preceding financial year are required to spend a minimum of 2 per cent of their average net profit of the

preceding three financial years on CSR activities. Failure to comply can attract penalties of up to ₹1 crore.

The notification defines ZCZP instruments as securities issued by not-for-profit organisations (NPOs) registered on the SSE segment of a recognised stock exchange. Such organisations will be permitted to undertake projects with a duration of not more than three succeeding financial years from the date of issuance. In the event of delisting or termination of the instrument, any unspent amount will have to be transferred to funds specified under the approved list of CSR activities.

DEMAND CATALYST

"India Inc spends close to ₹35,000 crore annually on CSR, and even a modest share of that routed through a listed and regulated platform could create the kind of demand the exchange has

lacked so far," said Manpreet Singh, Partner and Sustainability Practice Leader at Grant Thornton Bharat.

Sandeep Jhunjhunwala, Partner at Nangia Global Advisors, said the framework creates a more credible and governance-driven channel for CSR deployment.

Singh pointed to two potential limitations. First, the rules exempt these instruments from independent impact assessment requirement on the assumption that exchange-mandated disclosures provide sufficient transparency. "Boards may want assurance that being listed is not necessarily the same as being independently verified," he observed. Second, the number of credible non-profit organisations currently listed on the SSE remains limited, raising questions about whether the supply of quality issuances can keep pace with the demand the new framework may generate.

‘Positive about FY27 despite global shocks; demand strong’

BIG CONCERN. Elgi Equipments MD flags Chinese dumping, calls for government action

bl.interview

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

As Coimbatore-based air compressor major Elgi Equipments grows in double digits in FY26, Managing Director Jairam Varadaraj said cost reductions and calibrated price hikes had helped the company to drive profitability in a year that was marred by geopolitical crises.

In an interaction, Varadaraj said he anticipates rising input costs to weigh on FY27 performance, but stressed that customer demand remains intact.

“Our current inquiry levels are also very strong. We have some strong cost reduction projects that could absorb some of the potential shocks. So overall, I think it’s positive,” he said. He also flagged Chinese dumping as a key concern for the air compressors and wider manufacturing sector, urging the government to ensure a level-playing field.

Edited excerpts:

Your revenue has grown 13 per cent, and profits by almost 23 per cent in FY26. What have been key drivers?

From a revenue point of view, biggest growth came from India and North America — these were the real growth engines for the top line.

All regions grew except Australia, which was also flat. Profitability wise, I think the team has done a fantastic job of recovering from the tariffs and making sure that we didn’t let it impact us. It’s a combination of marginal price corrections and a significant reduction in cost that



The government has got enough priorities. But, what the government can do is to level the playing field

JAIRAM VARADARAJ
Managing Director, Elgi Equipments



Covid-like dislocation. Now that we have found a logistic channel to get our compressors into West Asia , we are growing our sales. The biggest thing we are trying to do is build agility within the company as well as layers of fallback options so that we still protect our growth trajectory and aspiration even while we face these kinds of uncertainty.

Are you still on track to achieve the goal you set for Elgi to become the third largest air compressor maker globally by 2035-36?

It is on track. Our growth rate is two-and-a-half to three times what the market is growing, which means we are gaining share in the market.

Will we get there [to the goal]? Definitely we will. But our bigger challenge is to get there within that nine-year time frame. So that means we are working on and exploring avenues for disproportionate growth rather than growth. It’s a combination of both organic as well as inorganic opportunity.

What’s your AI strategy and approach? Is it real today or a hype?

Artificial intelligence is real. The biggest challenge for companies is to organise data. We need a coherent library of our data so that AI is able to go pick up the data and make sense out of it and then give intelligence to us. It’s still some ways to go, but I don’t think human beings are going to become redundant. What we will do is we will architect the company and the processes by which machines will do the brawn work and human beings will do brain work.

have to adjust their prices or accept a loss.

Will more government support be needed?

I think we all have to work to be independent. The government has got enough priorities. But, what the government can do is to level the playing field. It is disproportionately loaded in favour of China, today. There are a lot of Chinese products coming in that are just dumped into the market with no relevance to the actual cost of material. Along with their efforts to conserve foreign exchange, promote make in India, and other steps, I think the government should also really take a look at the dumping that is happening from China. Not just for Elgi, but in a larger national interest. I’m not asking for protectionism, but talking about fair game.

Given all these factors, what is your outlook for FY27?

The first quarter looks good. Our current inquiry levels are also very strong. We have some strong cost reduction projects that could absorb some of these potential shocks.

Overall, I think it’s positive. The West Asia impact is more on cost and not a

we have been able to achieve this. We were also hit by the crisis in West Asia. Fuel prices went up, and for some inexplicable reason, even metal commodity prices have gone up, but we anticipate the impact of that to be more in FY27.

What factors aided North America growth, despite the tariffs?

Mainly our commitment in the market and our go-to-market strategies. Second is we have also done some organisational [changes] to bring sharper focus to customers, distributors there. And that’s also helping. And we have a great line-up of products there.

What are your plans to manage the impact of the West Asia crisis?

The biggest uncertainty because of the West Asia crisis is the oil price, and I think the world is kind of coming to terms with living with the high prices.

Metal commodity prices have gone through the roof, and these are fundamental raw materials for us.

And so, we need to moderate [our plans] between recovery of profit and not losing share in the market. But, it is affecting everyone, so at some point, all the players

Centre’s infrastructure project additions jump 12-fold in Q4 FY26, led by highways

Yashaswani Chauhan
New Delhi

The number of newly-added infrastructure projects surged sharply in the January-March quarter of FY26, led overwhelmingly by road and highway projects, according to data compiled by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).

DATA FOCUS.

A total of 483 projects were added in Q4 FY26, compared with just 38 projects in the corresponding quarter last year, marking a more than 12-fold increase in project additions. The rise in project additions was accompanied by a sharp increase in project costs at ₹6.01 lakh crore, up 544.9 per cent y-o-y from ₹93,213 crore in Q4 FY25.

Project additions had remained relatively subdued through most of FY26. While 46 projects were added in Q1 FY26 with an original cost of ₹51,155 crore, the number of projects fell to 34 in Q2 FY26, though the cost rose to ₹2.03 lakh crore. In Q3 FY26, project additions improved to 76 projects worth ₹1.37 lakh crore. However, the Q2 data excludes newly-added projects not mentioned in the official documents for July and August.

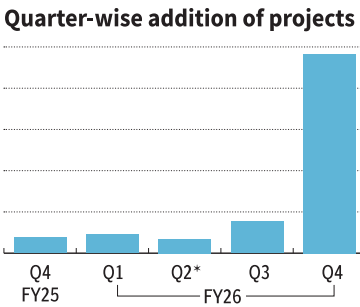
TOP PROJECTS

Roads and highways dominated the project pipeline in Q4 FY26, accounting for 439 out of the 483 projects added during the quarter.

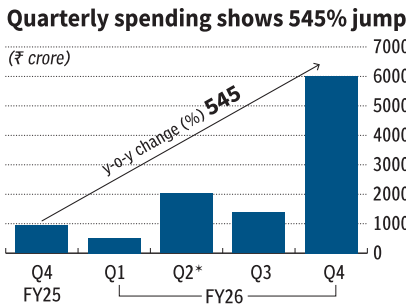
The sector alone contributed projects worth ₹4.13 lakh crore, or nearly 69 per cent of the total project cost added in the quarter.

The largest project in the roads and highways segment was the Guwahati Ring Road project in Assam, with an ori-

Mega projects gather pace



* Newly added projects not mentioned in the documents for July and August



Sectoral break-up of projects in Q4 FY26

Sector	Number of projects	Cost original (₹ crore)	Most expensive project (₹ crore)
Roads & highways	439	4,12,664	Guwahati Ring Road in Assam (5,729.47)
Transmission & distribution	8	56,840	Rajasthan Part I Power Transmission (25,000)
Coal	5	31,885	Jayant Expn. [20 to 38 mtpa] (25,560.48)
Electricity generation	1	29,948	Nabinagar Super Thermal Power Project, Stage-II (29,948)
Water resources	2	24,086	Ken-Betwa Linking Development Project (21,030)
Urban public transport	3	23,269	Delhi Metro Rail Phase V A (12,014.91)
Oil & gas	6	15,550	Petro Resid Fluidized Catalytic Cracking [PRFCC] Unit and its associated facilities at Mumbai Refinery (13,626)
Healthcare	15	4,575	Establishment of new GMC Korba (325)
Railways	1	969	Devgarh Madariya-Nathdwara Gauge Conversion [82.54 km] part of Marwar-Mavli Gauge Conversion (968.92)
Logistics infrastructure	1	763	Integrated Multi Modal Logistics Hub at Nangal Chaudhary in Haryana - Other Trunk Infrastructure Development Phase I (763)
Aviation & aviation infrastructure	1	363	Development of Keshod Airport (363.1)
Education	1	199	1,000-seater boys hostel, 500-seater girls hostel, 1.5-mld sewage treatment plant and faculty residence - 72 nos. flats (198.97)

Source: MoSPI

ginal cost of ₹5,729 crore.

Transmission and distribution emerged as the second-largest sector by project cost, with eight projects worth ₹56,840 crore added during the quarter.

The most expensive project in the segment was Rajasthan Part I Power Transmission Ltd, costing ₹25,000 crore.

Coal sector projects worth ₹31,885 crore were added, led by the ₹25,560 crore Jay-

ant expansion project, which involves raising production capacity from 20 million tonnes per annum to 38 mtpa.

Electricity generation saw the addition of one large project, NTPC’s ₹29,948 crore Nabinagar Super Thermal Power Project Stage-II.

Water resources projects worth ₹24,086 crore were also added, including the ₹21,030 crore Ken-Betwa

Linking Development Project. Urban public transport projects worth ₹23,269 crore were added during the quarter, led by Delhi Metro Rail Phase V-A with an original cost of ₹12,015 crore. Other sectors witnessing additions included oil and gas, healthcare, railways, logistics infrastructure, aviation infrastructure and education, at comparatively smaller scales.

Execution delays drag Inox Wind profit down 44%

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Inox Wind Ltd reported a sharp 44 per cent year-on-year drop in consolidated net profit to ₹106 crore in the fourth quarter of FY26, as execution delays and supply chain disruptions weighed on near-term performance, even as the full-year profit edged up 3 per cent.

Revenue from operations declined 2.4 per cent to ₹1,244 crore during the quarter, impacted by execution bottlenecks, geopolitical tensions affecting supply chains, and delays in critical equipment and logistics support.

For the full fiscal FY26, consolidated net profit rose 3 per cent to ₹449 crore, while revenue grew 24 per cent y-o-y to ₹4,397 crore, supported by stronger execution activity over the course of the year.

Domestic market drives growth for MM Forgings amid global slowdown

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Chennai-based MM Forgings Ltd witnessed stronger traction in the domestic market during the March 2026 quarter, with India accounting for a higher share of revenue, even as demand from key export markets such as the US and Europe softened amid global economic uncertainties.

DOMESTIC SHARE UP

According to the company’s Q4FY26 and FY26 financial presentation, domestic sales contribution rose to 71 per cent in the fourth quarter from 63 per cent in the preceding quarter. In comparison, the US market share declined to 10 per cent from 15.5 per cent, while Europe’s contribution dropped to 16

per cent from 19 per cent. South America, however, showed improvement, with sales contribution increasing to 3.1 per cent from 1.1 per cent.

For Q4FY26, the company posted a 36 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to ₹45 crore, up from ₹33 crore last year. Revenue for the quarter increased 12 per cent to ₹423 crore from ₹377 crore.

For the full year FY26, consolidated net profit declined 18 per cent to ₹99 crore from ₹122 crore in FY25, despite revenue rising 4 per cent to ₹1,606 crore from ₹1,548 crore.

In FY26, sales in India increased to 64.5 per cent as against 61.5 per cent in the previous year; Europe to 20 per cent (12 per cent); US to 10.3 per cent (16 per cent) and South America to 3.9 per



Vidyashankar Krishnan, CMD, MM Forgings Ltd

cent (7.9 per cent), the presentation said.

Vidyashankar Krishnan, CMD, MM Forgings Ltd, said global economic conditions during FY26 remained mixed due to geopolitical developments, regional conflicts, trade uncertainties, shifting trade policies among major economies and commodity price volatility.

GACL to set up high-purity hydrogen peroxide plant for semiconductor and solar applications

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

The state-run Gujarat Alkalies and Chemicals Ltd (GACL) on Friday said it will set up a 5,000 tonnes per annum (TPA) high-purity grade hydrogen peroxide plant at Dahej in south Gujarat, targeting niche applications in the semiconductor and solar manufacturing value chain.

The board of directors on

Friday approved an estimated investment of ₹67 crore for the project, which will produce electronic-grade hydrogen peroxide used in advanced electronics manufacturing processes.

The new facility is aimed at catering to rising demand from semiconductor fabrication units and solar cell manufacturers, as India expands its domestic electronics and clean energy production ecosystem.

MANUFACTURING UNITS

“This will enable the company to produce high-purity grade hydrogen peroxide for niche applications in semiconductor fabrication, solar cell manufacturing and other advanced electronics applications for which manufacturing units are being put up in India,” the company stated in a regulatory filing. The project is expected to



Avantika Singh, Managing Director, GACL

be commissioned within 18 months from the zero date, defined as the kick-off meeting with the technology supplier.

Once operational, the plant is expected to generate annual revenue of around ₹42 crore, according to the company. The company said the project will be funded through internal accruals, with any additional requirement to be met through bor-

rowings, if needed. On the operational side, GACL is focusing on reducing energy costs through greater use of renewable power and process efficiencies.

“Energy is a continued focus area for the company and during FY26 the company could reduce energy cost as compared to previous year on account of increased share of renewable power,” Avantika Singh, MD of the company, said.

RENEWABLE ENERGY

She added that the share of renewable energy in the company’s total power consumption has increased significantly. “During FY26, the share of renewable energy has increased to 35.7 per cent from 29.7 per cent,” she said. GACL is also investing in technology upgrades and digitisation to improve operational efficiency.

Toyota Urban Cruiser Ebella to arrive mid-June after four-month delay, to be priced ₹23.60 lakh

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Toyota Kirloskar Motor (TKM) on Thursday announced the price of its first mass-market electric SUV, the Urban Cruiser Ebella, at ₹23.60 lakh (ex-showroom) for the sole E3 variant, formally entering India’s increasingly crowded electric SUV market that includes the Maruti Suzuki e Vitara, Hyundai Creta Electric, Tata Curvv EV, Mahindra BE 6 and MG ZS EV.

The top-spec Maruti Suzuki e Vitara Alpha Dual Tone is priced lower at ₹20.01 lakh (ex-showroom). The pricing announcement ends more than four months of market speculation around the delayed launch timeline.

TKM had unveiled the Urban Cruiser Ebella in



MARKET ENTRY. TKM had unveiled the Urban Cruiser Ebella in Mumbai on January 20

Mumbai on January 20, and opened bookings on the same day.

However, the absence of pricing for over four months had triggered speculation around possible supply-chain and allocation issues within the Toyota-Suzuki partnership.

PRIORITISING OUTPUT

Industry discussions centred on whether Maruti Suzuki

was prioritising production and exports of the e Vitara ahead of Toyota’s version of the vehicle.

Thursday’s pricing announcement, along with Toyota confirming that the vehicle will start reaching dealerships by the second week of June, effectively puts an end to much of that speculation.

The Urban Cruiser Ebella shares its platform, battery

pack and motor setup with the Maruti Suzuki e Vitara, reflecting the broader Toyota-Suzuki global alliance that has already produced multiple rebadged products in India.

Both SUVs are built on the HEARTECT-e platform and use a 61 kWh battery pack paired with a 128 kW motor producing 189 Nm of torque.

Toyota, however, is positioning the Ebella as the more premium offering.

PANORAMIC SUNROOF

The E3 variant comes equipped with features such as a panoramic sunroof, sliding and reclining rear seats, JBL premium audio system, ventilated front seats, 18-inch alloy wheels and 12-colour ambient lighting — features absent on the top-spec Maruti Suzuki e Vitara Alpha Dual Tone.

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QUICKLY.

Forex reserves fall
\$7.5 b to \$681.38 billion



Mumbai: The country's forex reserves dropped \$7.511 billion to \$681.384 billion during the week ended May 22, the RBI said on Friday. In the previous reporting week, the kitty had dropped \$8.094 billion to \$688.894 billion. For the week ended May 22, foreign currency assets decreased \$2.872 billion to \$543.032 billion, the central bank's data showed. [PTI](#)

Services exports rise
12.7% in April: RBI

Mumbai: India's services trade saw an expansion in imports and exports during April, according to the Reserve Bank of India. The data showed that exports grew by 12.7 per cent to \$37.021 billion in April, registering the highest growth in the calendar year. Imports also expanded 8.9 per cent to \$18.417 billion in April, according to the RBI data. [PTI](#)

India, Canada push trade pact alongside law enforcement focus

MOVING FORWARD. Goyal, Sidhu launch investment forum; Canada trade mission to visit India later this year

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India and Canada are advancing their bilateral free trade agreement negotiations focussed on a year-end completion target amid Ottawa's "two-track" approach that will allow it to speed up economic dialogue while parallelly pursuing public safety and cooperation on law enforcement, sources said.

In a joint statement issued on Friday following their bilateral meeting, Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and his Canadian counterpart Maninder Sidhu reaffirmed the year-end timeline for the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) and launched the Canada-India Trade and Investment Forum to bring together business leaders.

"They (the two Ministers) underscored CEPA's importance in expanding market ac-



FOSTERING TIES. Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal with Canada's Minister of International Trade Maninder Sidhu in Ottawa [PTI](#)

cess, supporting resilient supply chains, and enabling two-way economic growth," the statement noted.

TRADE MISSION

Minister Sidhu confirmed that Canada will lead a 'team Canada trade mission' to In-

dia later this year, reflecting the strong interest of Canadian businesses in expanding their presence in the Indian market and the shared ambition to deepen commercial partnerships, the statement added. The two countries aim to reach \$50 billion in bi-

lateral trade within five years while boosting Canadian investments.

Free trade talks between India and Canada went into deep freeze in late 2023 after diplomatic ties hit a historic low over allegations of a "potential link" between agents of the Indian government and the June 2023 assassination of Canadian Khalistani activist Hardeep Singh Nijjar in British Columbia.

However, political friction eased since Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney took office in mid-2025 and terms of reference for the CEPA were signed during his India visit in March this year.

Canadian Trade Minister Sidhu clarified this week that his government will keep pursuing its law enforcement objectives and fight transnational repression with cooperation from India while pushing for enhancement in bilateral trade. "The two (public safety and economic cooperation) have to

go hand in hand. And we will not back away from that," Sidhu said in an interview with Canadian television.

CEPA TALKS

The Minister underlined that the economic dialogue with India was very important and he was leading it through the trade negotiations. Goyal has just concluded his visit to Canada leading the largest business delegation of over 150 representatives and the two sides also held a technical round of negotiations for the CEPA.

Sidhu said that like-minded partners such as the UK, the EU and New Zealand had already signed similar pacts with India and he wanted to make sure that Canadian businesses stay competitive. "Those countries have an early movers' advantage I want to make sure Canadian businesses are not left out," he said in his TV interview.

Energy prices, CAD, balance of payments big priorities right now: CEA

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran on Friday said managing macroeconomic fundamentals like the balance of payments and current account deficit has assumed a larger priority for the government right now as the West Asia conflict has triggered a massive global energy shock.

Speaking at an event on securitisation, Nageswaran said the West Asia conflict had led to a "energy shock" where the prices had moved north after the supply impact due to issues in the Strait of Hormuz.

"In the current context of having to deal with the energy price, energy shock, current account deficit (CAD) and the balance of payments (BoP), etc. These, therefore, have assumed a much larger priority, urgency at this point," Nageswaran said.

Refraining from giving any policy prescriptions on any securitisation front, Nageswaran stressed that the financial market had to keep up with the activity in the real sector and reminded that it was the extra focus on derivative products which led to the Global Financial Crisis in 2008.

When asked specifically



V Anantha Nageswaran, Chief Economic Advisor

about the ₹3 lakh annual income limit leading to qualification as microfinance, Nageswaran said he is against this system of putting numerical thresholds and would rather like the policy to come out with ratios on the same.

Income thresholds when the economy was \$1 trillion in size cannot be the same when the economy has grown to over \$4 trillion, and the average incomes have also grown.

PRIORITY LENDING

On the priority sector lending (PSL) mandate, Nageswaran said the industry must thank the PSL mandate as it is leading to higher volumes.

PSL is a Reserve Bank of India mandate that requires banks to allocate a specific percentage of their adjusted net bank credit to under-served economic sectors.

Almost 20% of 784 districts see high petrol, diesel sales as industrial users throng retail outlets

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Almost 20 per cent of the roughly 784 districts in the country are witnessing a rise in demand for petrol and diesel, partly driven by the farm sector and partly due to industrial users crowding retail outlets (ROs) for cheaper diesel supplies.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Oil Ministry, said: "Unusually high sales and heavy crowding is observed at ROs in certain areas. However, it is informed that there are adequate stocks of petrol and diesel available at all petrol pumps in the country."

The ROs in more than 150 districts registered over 30 per cent growth in petrol sales. Besides, another 14 districts reported sales rising by 100 per cent, she added.

Diesel sales rose more than 30 per cent in 156 districts, while six districts reported a 100 per cent growth in sales. Around 156 districts witnessed over 30 per cent jump in diesel sales. Also, 14 districts witnessed sales doubling, she said.

India has a total of around 1.03 lakh ROs, of which the three PSU OMCs — Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation — control more than 90 per cent.

The government is already



PEAK DEMAND

- Retail outlets in more than 150 districts registered over 30% growth in petrol sales
- Diesel sales rose over 30% in 156 districts
- India has a total of around 1.03 lakh retail outlets

tracking the pattern where industrial users are buying cheaper fuel from ROs of PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs), which is earmarked for retail consumers such as common man and farmers.

"States/UTs have been requested to form special squads and take action on malpractice of bulk consumers and hoarders taking supplies meant for retail consumers, black marketing, unauthorised stocking and diversion of petroleum products under relevant provisions of EC Act and Control orders issued thereunder. Industry associations

have been requested to advise their members to purchase diesel from authorised procurement channels," Sharma added.

ENFORCEMENT ACTION

On enforcement action related to petrol and diesel, she said that during the last two days, about 900 raids were conducted wherein 417 litres of petrol and 75,715 litres of diesel was seized, 12 FIRs were registered and 15 persons were arrested across the country. Similarly, the surprise inspections by the PSU OMCs officials are also continuing.

Similarly, inspections at

more than 4,660 retail outlets have been conducted in the last 4 days.

Penalties have also been imposed on 73 retail outlets, and 562 retail outlets have been put under suspension.

The Informal GoM, headed by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, on Wednesday took stock of the petrol, diesel, LPG and natural gas supply situation in the country and deliberated on the pattern of bulk diesel users unethically buying fuel earmarked for retail consumers.

Separately on the same day, the Oil Ministry said that under the government's direction, and as a deliberate act of consumer protection during the ongoing West Asia disruption, the OMCs have refrained from passing through the full international price into domestic retail sales. This cushion is intended for retail consumers: Households, two-wheeler commuters, and farmers at the pump. It is not extended to industrial procurement, where pricing tracks international actuals as a matter of standing policy.

Industrial consumers, who divert their purchases from the industrial channel to the retail pump, capture this cushion at the cost of the ordinary citizen.

They also concentrate demand at the pump in a way that produces local shortages where none would otherwise exist, it added.

US-India trade deal could be finalised in the coming months: Sergio Gor



CLOSE TO CONSENSUS. US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor (right) and US Under Secretary of State for Public Diplomacy and Public Affairs Sarah B Rogers being presented a memento during the US-India Trust Initiative event in New Delhi on Friday [PTI](#)

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Donald Trump administration is actively identifying new global centres of power and is expanding its partnership with India, recognising the country's immense growth potential, US Ambassador Sergio Gor stated on Friday.

Speaking at an event at the Indian Institute of Technology, New Delhi, Gor expressed strong optimism that an interim India-US trade deal could be finalised in the "coming weeks and months".

"When President Trump came into office a year and a half ago, one of the things that the US took an account of is, where is the world heading. For too long, those centres of power, have stayed in places that have become outdated. One of the things this administration has done is identifying new centres of power. To me, to the President, to the administration the importance of India is now... We realised the potential that India has, we see the growth India has, not only economically but strategically too...," Gor pointed out

that India and US economic ties were growing rapidly and the US-India trade deal could be signed very soon as most of the things were finalised.

US TEAM COMING

"Just last week, India had sent a team to Washington DC to finalise the last 1 per cent of that trade deal. Next week we will welcome a US delegation here to continue those talks. We fully expect that the trade deal will be signed over the next few weeks and months," he added.

The US Ambassador said the US was recalibrating its policy on export controls which could help partnership in high-technology areas. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who recently concluded his four-day India visit, was also positive about the trade pact. He said that the two sides would "wind up with a trade agreement" that is enduring and mutually beneficial.

India, however, is cautious and wants the tariff situation in the US to fully unfold before it takes on firm commitments and seals the deal, sources said.

APPOINTMENT



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1.	Director (Academics)	Mumbai	01	Level 13 (123100-215900)	29.44	50 years
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For further details viz. qualification, experience, procedure for submission of application etc., please visit website www.icsi.edu/careers on and from 30.05.2026. Interested candidates may apply only through electronic mode (Online). Last date for submission of application (Online) is 19.06.2026. Reservation policy will be applicable as adopted by the "ICSI" in its Service Rules. The "ICSI" reserves the right to increase/decrease or even not to fill up any posts as per its requirement.



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LPG production hits a record 52,000 tonnes/day

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The production of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) has hit a record 52,000 tonnes per day (TPD) from roughly 46,000 TPD earlier this month as refineries such as Vadinar resumed operations after a maintenance shut down in April.

The current demand for the critical cooking fuel, which is used by more than 33 crore households, is around 72,000 TPD, lower than the normal demand of around 80,000 TPD, as LPG consumption generally declines during summers.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in Oil Ministry, said: "We have sufficient stocks of petrol, diesel, and LPG. Adequate inventories of natural gas and crude oil have also been secured. All our refineries are operating at optimum levels, and LPG production is at an all-time high of around 52,000 TPD. No dry-out has been reported at LPG distributorships."

The growth in production is due to some refineries, such as the Nayara Energy-operated Vadinar facility, resuming operations after a maintenance shut down in April-May.

Average LPG production had declined to around 46,000-47,000 TPD in the first week of April compared to 50,000 TPD achieved in the last week of March.

GEOPOLITICAL SITUATION

The LPG supply continues to be affected by the prevailing geopolitical situation in West Asia and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz (SoH), which has almost completely choked more than half of the country's demand.

The country imports 60 per cent of its domestic demand, of which 90 per cent comes from Middle East Gulf (MEG) region.

As per the International Energy Agency (IEA), closure of the SoH has adversely impacted 430,000 barrels per day (kb/d) of LPG cargoes during March-April 2026.

In March 2026, the volumes of LPG exported through the Strait fell by around 80 per cent, dropping from 1.5 million barrels per day (mb/d) on average in 2025 to 0.3 mb/d.

Though India secured some supplementary supply from alternative sources, a vessel from the US needs around 40 days to reach Mumbai, compared with 4-5 days from the SoH.

PAN ELECTRONICS (INDIA) LIMITED

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GSTIN : 29AABCP0469N4ZV, CIN: L00309KA1982PLC004960

EXTRACT OF STANDALONE AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026 [Regulation 47 (1) (b) of the SEBI/ (LODR) Regulations, 2015] (Rs. in Lakhs)

Sl. No	Particulars	Year ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)	Year ended 31 March 2025 (Audited)	Quarter ended 31 Dec 2025 (Unaudited)
1.	Total Income	3,32,86,569	4,82,64,142	43,64,530
2.	Net Profit for the period (before tax, Exceptional items)	(2,08,57,565)	(3,74,27,081)	(43,71,144.29)
3.	Net Profit for the period before tax, (after Exceptional items)	(2,08,57,565)	(3,74,27,081)	(43,71,144.29)
4.	Net Profit for the period after tax	(2,08,57,565)	(3,74,27,081)	(43,71,144.29)
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	0	0	0
6.	Equity share Capital	4,00,00,000	4,00,00,000	4,00,00,000
7.	Other Equity (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance sheet	(35,40,15,396)	(33,31,57,830)	(34,62,07,256)
8.	Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) - Not annualised Basic & Diluted	(5.21)	(9.36)	(1.09)

Notes :

- The above financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on May 29th, 2026.
- The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Audited Financial Results for the year ended March 31, 2026 filed with BSE Ltd. Under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Audited Financial Results are available on the company's website and website of BSE Ltd. at www.bseindia.com
- The Complete results can also be accessed by scanning below QR Code:



For and on behalf of Board of Directors
Sd/-
Gullu Gellaram Talreja
Managing Director
DIN:01740145

Place : Bengaluru
Date : 29.05.2026

AVT NATURAL PRODUCTS LIMITED

Regd. Office : 60, Rukmani Lakshmiapathy Salai, Egmore, Chennai – 600 008.
Tele.fax: (+91) 44 28584147, Email : avtnpl@avtnatural.com, Website : www.avtnatural.com
CIN : L15142TN1986PLC012780.

EXTRACT FROM THE FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31ST MARCH, 2026 (Rs. in Lakhs except for EPS)

Sl. No		Particulars	Standalone				Consolidated			
			Quarter Ended	Quarter Ended	Year Ended	Year Ended	Quarter Ended	Quarter Ended	Year Ended	Year Ended
			31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025
			Audited							
1	Total income from operations	21,641.62	14,288.02	68,377.05	52,204.26	22,648.97	15,682.47	71,322.95	55,886.46	
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and / or Extraordinary items)	2,574.75	1,642.58	6,918.45	5,175.91	3,040.75	1,970.12	8,265.60	6,313.29	
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary items)	2,574.75	1,642.58	6,918.45	5,175.91	3,040.75	1,970.12	8,265.60	6,313.29	
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary items)	1,928.87	1,210.55	5,385.15	3,806.68	2,202.14	1,435.73	6,480.61	4,822.70	
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	1,685.63	1,398.13	4,976.76	3,805.42	2,270.17	1,642.79	6,435.88	4,905.52	
6	Equity Share Capital	1,522.84	1,522.84	1,522.84	1,522.84	1,522.84	1,522.84	1,522.84	1,522.84	
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the Previous Year	-	-	-	48,378.92	-	-	-	49,115.96	
8	Earnings per share (face value of Re.1/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) (not annualized)									
	a) Basic :	1.27	0.79	3.54	2.50	1.45	0.94	4.26	3.17	
	b) Diluted :	1.27	0.79	3.54	2.50	1.45	0.94	4.26	3.17	

Notes:

- The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly/ Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/ Annual Financial results are available on the websites of the Stock Exchange (BSE: www.bseindia.com) and NSE: www.nseindia.com) and also on the website of the Company, www.avtnatural.com.
- The Board of Directors of the company in their meeting held on May 28, 2026 recommended a final dividend of Re.0.45 per share (45%) with face value of Rs.1/- each amounting to Rs. 685.28 Lakhs. This is in addition to interim dividend of Re. 0.35 per share (35%) with face value of Rs.1/- each declared for the year 2025-26 by the Board amounting to Rs. 532.99 Lakhs. The aggregate of dividend for the year 2025-26 including the final dividend amounts to Re. 0.80 per share (80%) with face value of Rs.1/- each amounting Rs. 1218.27 Lakhs.



Place : Chennai
Date : 28.05.2026

AJIT THOMAS
CHAIRMAN

QUICKLY.

Hero Super Splendor XTEC 2.0 launched at ₹86,500



The Indian marque updated its popular 125 cc commuter with fresh styling, added tech and improved efficiency. Powered by a 124.7 cc engine producing 10.7 bhp and 1.08 kg-m, the motorcycle claims a fuel efficiency of an astounding 72 kpl. Key additions include bluetooth-enabled digital instrumentation, USB type-C charging, hazard lights, front disc brake and Hero's i3S and ISG technologies.

Triumph Street Triple 765 RX available at ₹13.91 lakh



The sharper track-focused alternative to the Street Triple RS has finally made its debut in India. While the 765 cc inline-triple engine remains unchanged, producing 128.2 bhp and 8.16 kg-m, the RX gets fully adjustable Öhlins NIX30 front forks, clip-on handlebars, a dedicated performance seat and exclusive RX styling. Available only through 2026, the RX carries a more committed riding posture and enhanced chassis hardware.

MG Majestor launched at ₹41 lakh



JSW MG Motor India's new flagship ICE SUV is powered by a 2.0-litre twin-turbo diesel engine producing 215 bhp and 48.8 kg-m, paired to an 8-speed automatic gearbox with 4x2 and 4x4 options. What sets it apart are its in-your-face styling, triple differential locks, multiple terrain modes and a feature-rich cabin with ADAS, massage seats and a panoramic sunroof. The Majestor goes up against the likes of the Toyota Fortuner.

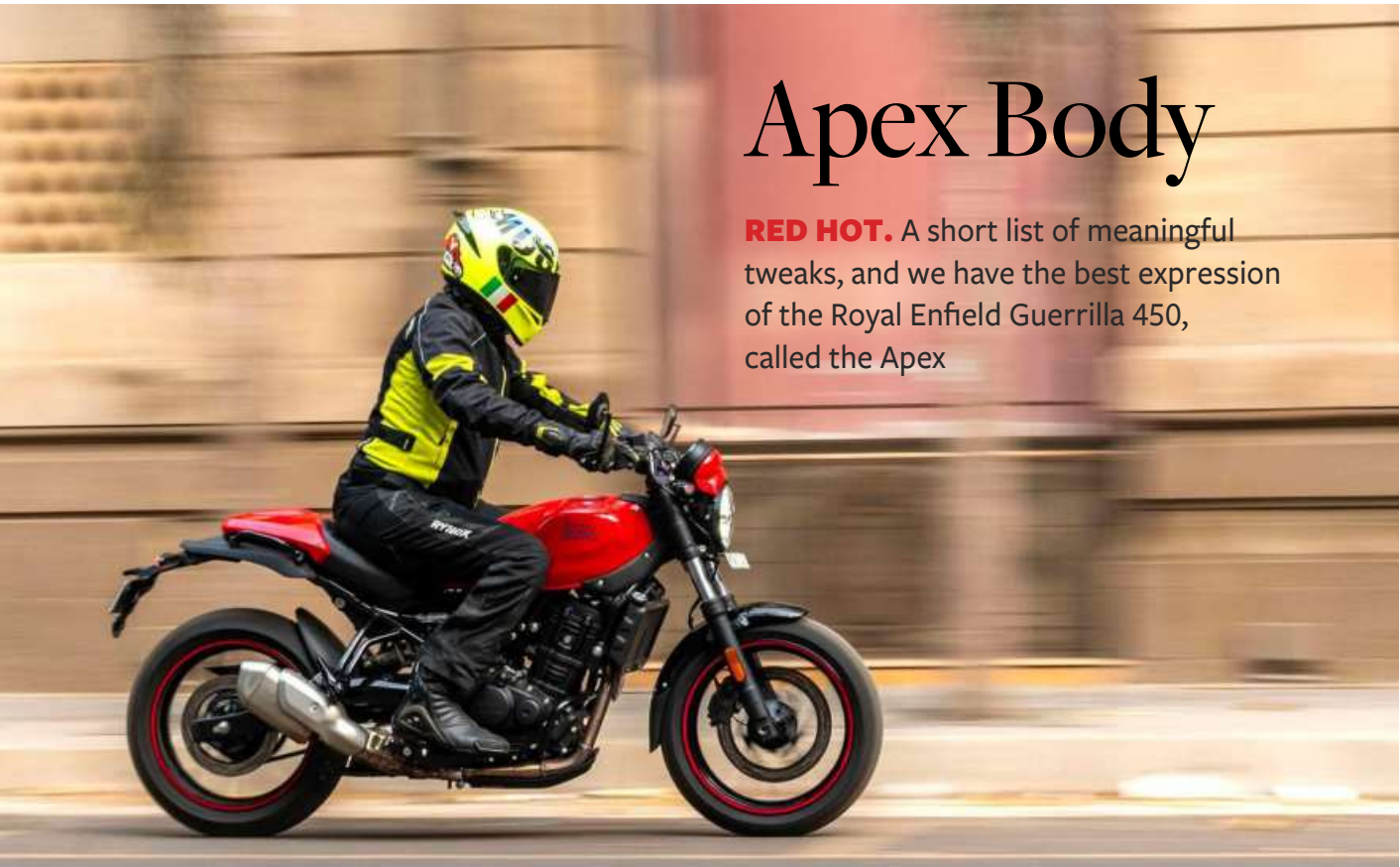
@TheMotorGram

Kartik Ware

When the Royal Enfield Guerrilla 450 first arrived in 2024, it proved to be a competent motorcycle for the most part. However, it was trying to be two things at once — a roadster and a scrambler. The latter part was visually implied because it sported tyres with a dual-purpose design, though the rest of the bike made it amply clear that it belonged firmly on the road. Added to that were the largely 'pop art graffiti' range of colours that made one squint with confusion. Now, the addition of this new variant, called the Apex, corrects that and takes the Guerrilla further in the direction it should've aimed at from the beginning.

The Apex comes in this rather fetching shade of red, with the addition of small fairing and a removable seat cowl, which makes it look a lot more desirable. The visual add-ons make the motorcycle immediately look more cohesive than the regular Guerrilla, finishing with the fat and sporty Vredestein Centauro ST+ tyres. The new lower and flatter aluminium handlebar gives it more of a forward-set stance, and the 'bar-end mirrors do their part in putting the 'retro' in 'neo-retro'. The cycle parts are all black-out, which lets the red attract all the attention, leaving only the all-metal exhaust to guide the lower visual line. Fit and finish is of above-average quality, too.

The Apex carries the same 452 cc Sherpa single-cylinder over-



square engine that makes 39.45 bhp and 4 kg-m in a package that has a kerb weight of 185 kg. That makes it heavier than other machines of its kind, for sure, but it doesn't really get in the way of the riding experience. It comes with two ride modes, Street and Sport, and has the same intake roar under hard acceleration as before; Royal Enfield claims that the engine offers 90 per cent of its torque from 3000 rpm, and there's no reason to suspect oth-

erwise. The Apex displayed a marked surge in grunt at said rpm every time I twisted the throttle, which quickly got addictive. Off the throttle, too, there were pleasing sounds issuing from the end can, which is always a plus.

SMOOTH OPERATOR Overall gearing is a bit on the taller side, so the gear lever does get a moderate workout at lower revs. However, mid-range is the place to be on this motorcycle,

Apex Body

RED HOT. A short list of meaningful tweaks, and we have the best expression of the Royal Enfield Guerrilla 450, called the Apex

where its torque-rich nature comes across the best. Sustained high-rpm riding, however, will result in tingling hands and feet thanks to the motor's buzzy nature. At real-world speeds, though, everything remains relatively smooth and composed. The biggest change in terms of dynamics is the switch to grippy road tyres, and it completely changes the motorcycle. The Apex can be ridden hard into its engine's potential at all sorts of

lean angles, and it's all thanks to the tyres. Turn-in is quick and the bike is light enough on its feet to make the rider forget the weight mentioned in its spec sheet. Ride quality is decent for this type of motorcycle, too; it's firm enough to be stable without breaking your back. Under hard braking, the rear does move around a bit, but that only adds to the entertainment factor rather than being a serious instability issue. Speaking of the brakes, the Apex's twin-disc setup

performs satisfactorily despite having to rein in all that mass. As for the niggles, there's the poor LED headlight which is up to no mark whatsoever. There's also the small-ish 11-litre fuel tank, which may annoy on longer rides. And it was impossible for me to get the switchgear toggle to select the correct option on the screen. Nonetheless, while I was riding it, the Guerrilla 450 Apex came across as an involving motorcycle that was also easy to trust. At

₹2.49 lakh (ex-showroom introductory price), the bike is a more focused and complete offering.

Now, if the rumours of a scrambler based on the Sherpa platform are true, then we'll get the perfect duo that was promised with the first Guerrilla. Meanwhile, if you're not chasing headline numbers but want a reassuring yet fast motorcycle, the Guerrilla 450 Apex has a lot going right for it.

@TheMotorGram



Say Watt?

STAR POWER. The Mercedes-Benz CLA 250+ attempts to lure you into stargazing the electrified way. Easier said than done?

YASH GAWDE

Ruman Devmane

It took me a while to wrap my head around the Mercedes-Benz CLA 250+. This is the newest Mercedes EV in India, intended to serve as the stepping stone into its world of electrified cars, and it also happens to be a firmly first-world car aimed at a very young buyer. A bit hard to relate, as you can imagine, but it's armed with what has historically ended most heated automotive debates — a three-pointed star. Is that all there is to it, though?

Let's get to know it a bit better, shall we? The CLA 250+ wears a ₹59 lakh (ex-showroom, Delhi) price tag; there's a lower-spec CLA 200, too, priced ₹55 lakh. The car you see here is the 250+ in AMG Line spec, which also happens to be the only kind you can buy. Staying true to the CLA stylebook, this new-gen car remains compact even as it has grown in some areas over its predecessors. There are EV elements to its design, bits of typical Mercedes sass and sporty undertones in some areas, and the overall effect is that of a contemporary, unmistakably youthful car that wears its illustrious badge with ease. So what if that front end isn't going to win hearts?

At the forefront of the CLA's design elements is the 'grille', which features 142 illuminated three-pointed stars laid evenly around the large (also illuminated) star emblem. The 'connected' light bar looks somewhat odd (it photographs especially underwhelmingly) but the rest of the CLA, fortunately, is quite appealing. Its swooping 'banana' profile, first introduced on the CLS nearly two decades ago, looks elegant and sporty, and it transitions neatly into the somewhat coupe-like rear end. The 18-inch AMG 5-spoke alloys

look great and fill up the wheel arches really well; the CLA 200 gets 18-inchers, too, but styled differently. Tyre width varies at either end, with 225/45 R18s up front and 255/40 R18s at the rear. The spare wheel is, as you'd expect, a space saver. In other news, the doors are frameless, which definitely adds to the CLA's sporty outlook.

CABIN CLASS

The cabin, while identical in its layout between both variants, is made remarkably more appealing thanks to the AMG-spec seats that are racy without being uncomfortable, but they aren't ventilated and that's a huge miss. On a hot and humid day, with the fixed glass roof (tinted, but without any sort of retractable shade), I can't say I was entirely at ease driving it around town. At night, it's less of a struggle for sure. In fact, in the dark is where you will also witness one of its cabin's party tricks — the ambient light themes. I think they really jazz up the cabin (some of the preset options look really nice) and certainly lend a sense of occasion.

The steering wheel, a flat-bottomed unit, is in line with the current-gen Mercs and feels great to grip, with a measured heft to it. The steering-mounted controls are neatly finished, too, although I'm not a fan of some bits (such as the volume control) which are touch-operated. A sudden blast of music in the middle of a tricky U-turn can be an irritant, to put it politely.

The 'dashboard' is essentially one elongated panel featuring two screens and while the displays are crisp and the functions are intuitively laid out, the screen-dependency is quite annoying. To have to disengage all the ADAS functions with every restart is quite trying, and I doubt it would ever grow on you. Sure, the CLA isn't the first to do so, but that still doesn't make it okay.



INSIDE PEEK. The CLA EV's cabin has sporty undertones, a giant twin-screen setup and neat finishes but space is at a premium in the rear

YASH GAWDE

The overarching theme of the CLA is, indisputably, its compactness. Courtesy the new MMA (Mercedes-Benz modular architecture) skateboard platform that lends itself to EV and ICE formats, Mercedes has been able to maximise space — the CLA is longer and wider than its predecessor — but not to a revelatory effect. In reality, the CLA still is a front-row-oriented car you can occasionally use as an actual four-seater. Five? Yes, if your friends happen to be figurines. With the high floor and its sloping roofline, the rear seat feels particularly cramped although, in all truthfulness, it's highly unlikely you'd buy one only to be chauffeur driven.

DRIVE TO DERIVE

It's when you take to the wheel, having turned off all the collision-avoidance systems), that you begin to get the proper CLA experience anyway. This is a car that can make urban commuting fun, helped immensely by its electric powertrain

and an impressive chassis. There's an 85-kWh battery at your disposal, and the single rear motor delivers a credible 268 bhp and 34.1 kg-m. If that sounds meaty on paper, it feels even more so, thanks to its well-calibrated mannerisms that help it emerge as something special. Its compactness becomes among the strongest tools in its arsenal and there's a 'connection' you develop with its intuitive responses that becomes addictive over time.

Over a gentle well-mannered drive across the city, the CLA 250+ felt predictable and quite sophisticated in how it responded to inputs. More indulgent driving can get proportionately more rewarding; the CLA can lay down some strong acceleration that, especially in this low-slung sedan format, feels delightfully engaging and fun. Okay, for reference, this is no substitute for the erstwhile CLA 45 AMG — that pocket-rocket managed a 0-100-kph time of 4.6 seconds; the CLA 250+ will do the same in a

claimed 6.7 seconds. In isolation, though, it still feels potent and exciting to a reasonable degree.

FIRST-WORLD ORDER

Firmly first world, did someone say? Yes, because the CLA 250+ assumes you live in an upscale locality with impeccable roads, with easy access to high-output charging stations. If that's an accurate description of your immediate surroundings, the CLA is almost too tempting a buy. If it isn't though, living with it might be a struggle beyond the novelty of bringing one home. The ride quality is firm but Mumbai's uniformly bumpy roads (save for some recent infrastructural marvels) resulted in a pretty uncomfortable experience. Also, while the range is phenomenal — 792 km (WLTP), which easily translates to well over 500 km even under aggressive driving — it will help hugely if you have access to a powerful charger. For instance, Mercedes claims you can add 400 km of range in just 20 minutes using a 240-kW DC charger. Using the more commonly available 60-kW charger, though, I was only able to add 100 km of range in 30 mins, taking the charge from 48 up to 62 per cent in the process.

Then, there is the question of its peers. Or perhaps there isn't. Sure, the CLA 250+ is objectively up against pretty competent rivals (the BMW iX1 LWB is the incumbent in this price category) and its pricing is undeniably steep given that it's a CBU import, but then it's not a car you'd necessarily consider to serve as a problem solver.

Buying yourself a Mercedes-Benz remains among the highest of India's automotive aspirations and the CLA 250+ is, thus, a rewarding enough continuation of that tradition.

@TheMotorGram



DEVIL'S DETAILS. The biggest upgrade is the tyres that make all the difference. The TFT screen looks and feels quite premium, and the engine is more than capable for all-round duty

YASH GAWDE

RBI to focus on customer protection, boosting credit ecosystem in FY27

TIGHT VIGIL. Central bank's agenda to focus on enhancing consistency in supervisory practices across entities

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India said on Friday that its agenda in the regulatory space in FY27 would be anchored around the two priorities — customer protection and strengthening the credit ecosystem.

Further, its supervisory agenda will focus on early identification of emerging risks, strengthening root-cause analysis and enhancing consistency in supervisory practices across regulated entities (REs).

On customer protection, the RBI said its focus is on strengthening the KYC framework, extending video-based identification to NRI customers and reviewing responsible business conduct directions, according to its



GOING DIGITAL. The RBI plans to expand the CBDC pilot to cover new use cases under the direct benefit transfer schemes

latest annual report for FY26.

On the credit side, review of directions on interest rates, credit risk management and market mechanisms for transfer and distribution of credit risk has been proposed, along with a new

framework for shared loan arrangements. Further, to enable the Boards of banks to utilise their time effectively, and to facilitate a more focused and qualitative engagement on matters of strategy and risk governance, the Reserve Bank

will rationalise the requirements emanating out of its instructions for placing matters before the Boards. The supervisory agenda will involve reviewing the risk-based approach for KYC/AML (anti-money laundering) supervision of scheduled commercial banks (SCBs), strengthening data-driven supervision through micro-data analytics and development of supervisory data quality index (sDQI) for tier-3 and tier-4 urban co-operative banks.

The Reserve Bank will also examine implementation of risk-based supervision framework for select non-banking finance companies NBFCs and UCBs.

DIGITAL CURRENCY

The RBI plans to expand the CBDC (Central Bank Digital Currency) pilot to cover new

use cases under the direct benefit transfer schemes and the domestic retail space, while exploring additional pilots on tokenisation of financial assets and widening participant coverage.

On cross-border payments, the central bank intends to operationalise bilateral CBDC pilots with select use cases and deepen engagement in multilateral projects.

The RBI said the unified lending interface will be scaled up through the onboarding of more data service providers and lenders. MuleHunter.ai™, a supervised machine learning model developed by Reserve Bank Innovation Hub for near-real-time identification of mule accounts, will be expanded across more banks with new features such as mule registry.

RBI balance sheet expanded 21% in FY26 led by rising valuation of gold

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) balance sheet expanded sharply in FY26, crossing ₹91.97 lakh crore and registering a growth of 20.6 per cent over the previous year. The expansion was driven largely by a surge in the value of the central bank's gold holdings and sharp rise in domestic investments.

At the same time, higher interest earnings from both domestic and foreign secur-



STEADY GROWTH. RBI's contingency fund balance increased to ₹5.68 lakh crore as of March 31, 2026, from ₹5.42 lakh crore

DATA FOCUS.

ities, coupled with sizeable foreign exchange gains, boosted the RBI's income during the year. The transfer to contingency buffer as a share of the balance sheet declined from 7.5 per cent to 6.5 per cent.

GOLD REVALUATION

The RBI's total assets and liabilities rose to ₹91.97 lakh crore in FY26 from ₹76.25 lakh crore in FY25. A key factor behind this increase was the dramatic rise in the value of its gold assets, which were valued at ₹10.94 lakh crore at the end of FY26, up 63.8 per cent from ₹6.68 lakh crore a year earlier.

The increase reflects the sharp appreciation in global gold prices since addition of gold to RBI's reserves was limited to 0.94 metric tonnes in FY26.

Another major driver was the expansion of domestic investments. Domestic investments held by the RBI rose 44.9 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹22.59 lakh crore in FY26 from ₹15.59 lakh crore in FY25. This was due to open market operations amounting to ₹8.8 lakh crore carried out by the RBI last fiscal year.

Meanwhile, foreign in-

Higher interest earnings from both domestic and foreign securities, coupled with sizeable foreign exchange gains, boosted the RBI's income during the year

vestments increased at a slower pace of 7.9 per cent, rising to ₹52.68 lakh crore from ₹48.84 lakh crore.

The central bank's contingency fund (CF) balance increased to ₹5.68 lakh crore as of March 31, 2026, from ₹5.42 lakh crore a year earlier.

The RBI report states that "as on March 31, 2026, amounts of ₹90,833.07 crore, ₹30,603.99 crore and ₹43,403.23 crore were charged to CF on account of debit balances in Investment Revaluation Account (IRA), Foreign Securities, Investment Revaluation Account (IRA) and Rupee Securities and Foreign Exchange Forward Contracts Valuation Account (FCVA)," respectively. This was due to the hardening of yields across the yield curve in major juris-

dictions. The charge to CF is reversed on the first working day of the following accounting year. Further, an amount of ₹1,09,379.64 crore was also provided towards CF to maintain the Available Realised Equity at the level of 6.5 per cent of the size of the balance sheet".

FOREX GAINS

The RBI's income received a significant boost from rising interest earnings. Interest income from holdings of rupee-denominated securities climbed 37.7 per cent to ₹1.18 lakh crore in FY26 from ₹0.85 lakh crore in FY25. Interest income from foreign securities also increased, rising 11 per cent to ₹1.08 lakh crore from ₹0.97 lakh crore.

Elevated US bond yields improved returns on the RBI's foreign securities portfolio, supporting growth in earnings from overseas assets.

Foreign exchange operations provided another major source of income. With the RBI net selling foreign currency amounting to \$53.13 billion in FY26, exchange gains from foreign exchange transactions rose to ₹1.69 lakh crore in FY26, up from ₹1.11 lakh crore in FY25.

Domestic bond yields likely to face upward pressure

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Domestic bond yields could face upward pressure if the global monetary easing cycle stalls or reverses in response to persistent oil price shocks amid fragile conditions in West Asia, cautioned the RBI in its latest annual report.

However, the government's commitment to fiscal consolidation, along with liquidity injection measures by the Reserve Bank, is expected to contain the upward pressure on yields.

Elevated sovereign yields may also exert pressure on financial institutions' invest-

ment portfolios, warned the report.

Nonetheless, on balance, supported by sound fundamentals and healthy balance sheets, the domestic financial system has sufficient buffers to withstand adverse shocks.

The report noted that the Government Securities (G-sec) yield curve steepened during the year (FY26).

"Short-term yields softened on the back of monetary policy easing, the RBI's liquidity injection measures and sovereign credit rating upgrade by an international rating agency; medium-term and long-term yields hardened, tracking move-



WORD OF CAUTION. Elevated sovereign yields may also exert pressure on financial institutions' investment portfolios

ment of sovereign yields in other countries amid intensification of geopolitical risks. Overall, the 10-year yield hardened by 49 basis points

in FY26," said the RBI report.

INDIA-US TRADE DEAL

The report observed that G-sec yields hardened since Q2

(July-September 2026) amid uncertainty over the India-US trade deal, receding expectations of further monetary easing, demand-supply mismatches and geopolitical tensions.

"In Q4FY26, yields traded with a hardening bias amid higher-than-expected gross market borrowings announced in the Union Budget 2026-27 and a sharp increase in crude oil prices following the escalation of West Asia conflict. On the final trading session of FY26, the 10-year generic G-sec yield crossed the 7 per cent mark for the first time since July 2024," the central bank report added.

Bank time deposits, debt MFs act as complementary investment avenues

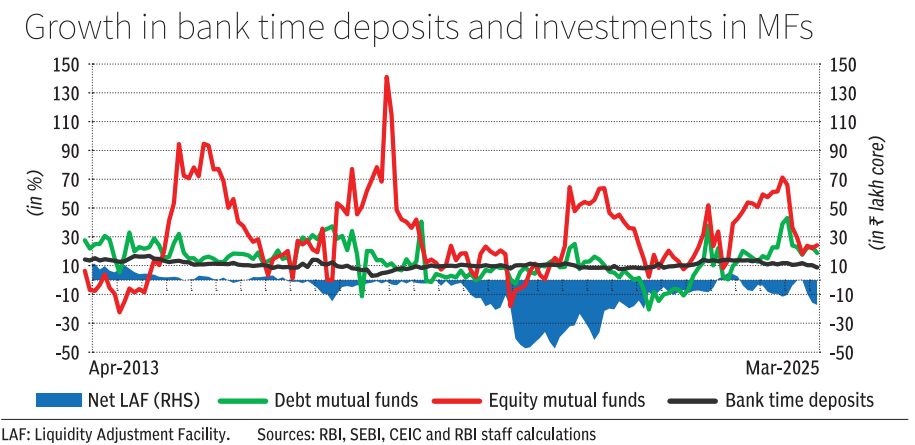
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Mumbai

Bank time deposits and debt mutual funds act as complementary investment avenues in both surplus and deficit liquidity regimes, according to an RBI analysis.

"One plausible explanation for this complementarity is that within India's bank-centric and evolving debt market, bank time deposits and debt mutual funds predominantly serve distinct investor segments. This structural segmentation minimises direct competition between the two instruments, fostering concurrent allocation rather than substitution," per the analysis.

DOMESTIC SAVINGS

The analysis, based on sample period between 2013-14 and 2024-25 using monthly data, found no statistically significant relation-



LAF: Liquidity Adjustment Facility. Sources: RBI, SEBI, CEIC and RBI staff calculations

ship between bank time deposits and equity mutual fund flows.

Time deposits with banks and mutual funds serve as important channels for mobilising domestic savings for investment to support economic activity, according to the RBI.

"While time deposits with banks are regarded as safe

and capital-protected instruments, the debt mutual funds provide market-linked returns from fixed-income securities, and the equity mutual funds may offer long-term capital gains with higher market risk," said the analysis.

"Recent evidence suggests that mutual funds have emerged as a major alternat-

ive investment avenue in India. For instance, between 2020-21 and 2024-25, on an average, outstanding bank time deposits grew by 10.7 per cent, while the assets under management (AUM) of debt mutual funds increased by 5.3 per cent, and the AUM of equity mutual funds expanded by 32.4 per cent," the analysis added.

Rupee increasingly being used for import & export invoicing

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

The rupee is being increasingly used for import and export invoicing over the years, showed data compiled by the RBI, which said the rupee internationalisation process has been mutually beneficial to all trading partners.

MEASURES TAKEN

Over the past few years, several measures have been undertaken by the RBI to enhance the role of rupee as an international currency through its increased usage for both current and select capital account transactions.

The RBI said the growing use of rupee as an invoicing and settlement currency is likely to offer protection against exchange rate risk, reduce the requirement for maintaining costly forex reserves in convertible curren-

cies and provide other benefits. In this context, the use of the domestic currency also facilitates the development of bilateral exchange rate markets and reduces transaction costs in foreign exchange transactions.

There has been a considerable pick-up in rupee-based invoicing and settlement since July 2022, said the RBI.

During the period between August 2022 and July 2025, the compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of imports and exports invoiced in rupee has been at 20.9 per cent and 12.7 per cent, respectively.

Further, the latest data on trade invoicing and settlement in rupee in FY26 exhibit a year-on-year growth for export invoicing (6.5 per cent), import invoicing (9.5 per cent), export settlement (2.7 per cent) and import settlement (41.2 per cent) over the corresponding

period of the previous year. In absolute terms, rupee invoicing in imports stood at ₹2.85 lakh crore in FY26, up from ₹2.60 lakh crore in FY25 and ₹1.94 lakh crore in FY24.

In the case of exports, the invoicing stood at ₹3.27 lakh crore in the last fiscal, up from ₹3.07 lakh crore in FY25 and ₹2.87 lakh crore in FY24, the data showed.

Rupee settlement in imports stood at ₹1.60 lakh crore in FY26, compared to ₹1.13 lakh crore in FY25 and ₹99,680 crore the year before. In case of exports, the settlements were valued at ₹1.72 lakh crore in FY26, ₹1.67 lakh crore in FY25 and ₹1.75 lakh crore in FY24.

The rupee internationalisation process has been mutually beneficial to all trading partners, and based on the principles of reciprocity, it has given a fillip to trade invoicing in several other emerging market currencies.

₹500 note volumes jump 11% in FY26, fake notes detected up 20%

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

The volume of ₹500 denomination banknotes in circulation increased about 11.2 per cent in FY26, reinforcing their dominance in India's currency ecosystem, according to the Reserve Bank of India's annual report.

The volume of ₹500 notes increased to 7,05,482 lakh pieces at March 2026-end, from 6,34,458 lakh pieces a year ago. In value terms, ₹500 notes in circulation increased to ₹35.27 lakh crore in FY26, from ₹31.72 lakh crore in FY25.

However, the detected counterfeit notes in the ₹500 denomination rose over 20 per cent during the fiscal year, said the RBI.

It said that ₹500 denomination banknotes continued to constitute the highest share of total banknotes in circulation in volume terms at 41.2 per cent, followed by ₹10 denomination notes at 16.1 per cent at March 2026-end.

From a value perspective, the ₹500 denomination notes outstanding form over 86 per cent of the currency in circulation.

Overall, the value and volume of banknotes in circulation increased 11.9 per cent and 10.5 per cent, respectively, during FY26, reflecting sustained demand for cash in the economy.

The central bank also noted that the withdrawal of ₹2,000 denomination notes from circulation, initiated in May 2023, continued during the year.

As of March 31, 2026, 98.45 per cent of the ₹3.56 lakh crore worth of ₹2,000 notes in circulation at the time of the announcement had been returned.

The total value as well as volume of coins in circulation increased 11.4 per cent and 4.5 per cent, respectively, in FY26, the RBI annual report showed.

Financial entities report over 10,000 cases of fraud involving ₹48,000 crore in FY26

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

Banks and financial institutions taken together reported 10,114 fraud cases involving ₹48,021 crore in FY26, against 23,722 cases involving ₹32,803 crore in FY25, according to the annual report for the Reserve Bank released on Friday.

An assessment of bank group-wise fraud cases over the last three years indicates that although the number of frauds for public and private sectors banks has reduced, the amount involved has increased over the years, said the RBI annual report.

DIGITAL FRAUDS

While the number of frauds was the highest under card/internet/digital payments category in FY24 and FY25, the advances category ac-

counted for the largest share in FY26. In value terms, frauds were concentrated in the advances category across three years.

Public sector banks (PSBs) reported a decline in the number of fraud cases in FY26 year-on-year, though the amount involved rose sharply to ₹35,709 crore.

State-owned banks reported 5,418 fraud cases during FY26, lower than 6,916 cases in FY25 and 7,446 in FY24. The amount involved in such frauds at PSBs was ₹23,617 crore in FY25 and ₹8,092 crore in FY24.

Private sector banks also reported a fall in the number of fraud cases to 3,956 in FY26 from 14,024 in the preceding fiscal year and 23,965 in FY24.

The amount involved in frauds at private banks stood at ₹11,399 crore in FY26

against ₹8,927 crore in FY25 and ₹2,667 crore in FY24. Foreign banks reported 210 fraud cases involving ₹290 crore during FY26, compared with 1,447 cases involving ₹181 crore in the preceding year.

Small finance banks reported 467 fraud cases involving ₹114 crore in FY26, while payments banks recorded 47 fraud cases amounting to ₹11 crore. A total of 8,640 fraud cases involving ₹40,774 crore in advances category were reported last fiscal year, compared to 7,924 cases involving ₹30,367 in FY25 and 4,105 cases involving ₹8,917 crore in FY24.

Card/internet/digital payments fraud cases stood at 293 involving ₹29 crore, significantly down from 13,332 (₹517 crore) during FY25 and 28,836 (₹1,452 crore) in FY24.

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Responding to the alleged disguising of extra interest payments as marketing expenditure on deposits placed by a Maharashtra government-owned entity, HDFC Bank on Friday stated this matter does not have a material impact on the financial statements and that the internal controls at the bank are robust.

MEDIA REPORT

Referring to BSE's May 27 e-mail seeking clarification from the bank on the media report, "HDFC Bank shares slide 2.5% amid reports of internal probe into ₹45 crore payment to state transport firm," the bank said on Friday: "We wish to state that in

line with the highest corporate governance standards of the bank, the internal audit function conduct reviews, identifies and presents its observations from time to time."

"As such, the observations of internal audit function are comprehensively addressed by the bank and that applies to the matter in question," the bank added.

VIGILANCE PROBE

The *Indian Express* reported that on March 12 the audit committee of HDFC Bank's Board had ordered a formal internal vigilance investigation into payments totalling ₹45 crore as "differential interest" (interest over and above the specified rate) made to the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation (MSRDC) on



its deposits during FY24 and FY25. The report alleged that instead of being credited directly to MSRDC's account as interest earned, the aforementioned amount was routed through the bank's marketing department, disguised as contributions to a road safety awareness campaign through four local vendors.

"This matter does not have a material impact on the financial statements and

the internal controls at the bank are robust. Accordingly, in our view, no requirement of making a disclosure under Regulation 30 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, is triggered. The bank continues to maintain sound financial and risk management practices, with robust systems of internal control and oversight. We remain committed to the highest standards of corporate governance and regulatory compliance," said the bank in a regulatory filing.

REGULATORY SCRUTINY

According to banking experts, the bank may face regulatory scrutiny and if found that rules were bent to source deposits, there could be enforcement action.

High stakes gamble

Karnataka leadership change, not without political risk

By replacing a mass leader of Siddaramaiah’s stature with an organisational loyalist like DK Shivakumar, the Congress may have fortified its machinery ahead of the May 2028 Assembly polls, but it has stumbled heavily on political messaging. The transition appears designed to jettison the burden of anti-incumbency while infusing the party rank and file with renewed momentum. It leverages Shivakumar’s ultimate differentiator as a lifelong party loyalist who began in the trenches of the NSUI.



Shivakumar’s hyper-focus on Bengaluru, the economic powerhouse driving Karnataka’s global tech stature, signals a strategic reorientation for the Congress. It marks the party’s expansion from a base of pro-poor welfarism, defined by its five guarantees, into a distinctly urban-centric political agenda. Yet, this shift is accompanied by growing unease. Public protests surrounding several of Shivakumar’s flagship urban infrastructure projects have cast a shadow over his tenure as Bengaluru Development Minister. It remains an open question whether citizens view these mega-projects as quality-of-life upgrades or lucrative conduits for rent-seeking.

In contrast, Siddaramaiah’s “11G Model” in his 2026 Budget speech, was centred on agriculture and rural development, and aimed at reducing regional disparities. According to the Economic Survey of Karnataka 2025-26, Bengaluru Urban records the highest per capita income in the State at ₹8.55 lakh, Kalaburagi in north Karnataka remains at the opposite end of the spectrum, with a per capita income of merely ₹1.44 lakh, significantly below even the national average. Holding the finance portfolio as well, Siddaramaiah was inclined to favour agriculture, industrial expansion and welfare. A study by the Institute for Social and Economic Change for the 16th Finance Commission observes that Karnataka fared well in per capita own-tax revenue and overall tax collection. Siddaramaiah is known for his espousal of the AHINDA social coalition, an alliance of minorities, backward classes and Dalits. It is seen as an attempt to consolidate numerically large but politically fragmented, non-dominant caste groups. Belonging to the Kuruba shepherd community within the OBC category, Siddaramaiah represents a break from the dominance of Lingayats and Vokkaligas in Karnataka politics. Shivakumar, a Vokkaliga leader, will now have to recalibrate these social equations carefully.

The Congress high command has taken care to prevent the succession from descending into a political melodrama. Although Siddaramaiah is too seasoned to display dissent publicly, the Congress can draw little comfort from the signals he has sent out since his resignation. He has already rejected the offer of a Rajya Sabha berth, choosing instead to remain in active mass politics. He retains the capacity to complicate the Congress’s calculations. Without his cooperation, this political experiment could yet prove to be an expensive gamble.

POCKET RAVIKANTH



Reason for bank deposit erosion

EQUITY FACTOR. The rise in bank equity capital has eaten into deposits. Household savings have moved into bank stocks



ABHIMAN DAS
SMITA ROY TRIVEDI

Where are all the deposits going? On April 15, Reserve Bank of India officials met commercial lenders urging them to bring in more ‘stable deposits. It is often argued that lack of deposit mobilisation, caused by a ‘shift in household savings into equities’, lies at the deposit conundrum impacting the Indian banking system (Bloomberg, April 15, 2026).

However, what if the root cause of deposit sluggishness lies within the bank itself? What if it is not savers queuing up for mutual fund, but rather investment in bank shares that is ultimately leading to this deposit-capital conundrum? We argue that the deposit growth slowdown is a by-product of two important facets of Indian banking: increased equity held by banks, as reflected in the growing market capitalisation of bank stocks and the increase in regulatory capital requirements.

BROAD TRENDS First, from early 2022, deposit growth started lagging the credit growth. The scissor effect between deposit and credit growth is not a new phenomenon. Also, a CD ratio of above 75 per cent is not a new occurrence. There are times (like during January 2018 to October 2019) when credit growth far outpaced deposit growth and CD ratio was above 75 per cent.

Second, credit growth fell sharply in July 2024 to 13.7 per cent year-on-year from 19.5 per cent in July 2023. This coincides with the period of regulator driven slowdown in unsecured personal loans, reduced bank lending to NBFCs, and a high base effect from the previous year.

Why is the deposit sluggishness a conundrum? While a common discourse on deposit sluggishness is that households are increasingly moving to capital markets and hence withdrawing from deposits, but this is half the story. Because any money invested in stock market must also show up in bank’s liabilities — ultimately it must be booked in a bank account. There may be compositional changes in term, saving and current deposits — in aggregate, deposits of capital market activity must find a place in bank’s liability.

The root cause of deposit crunch plausibly lies somewhere else, not just the portfolio allocation by households.

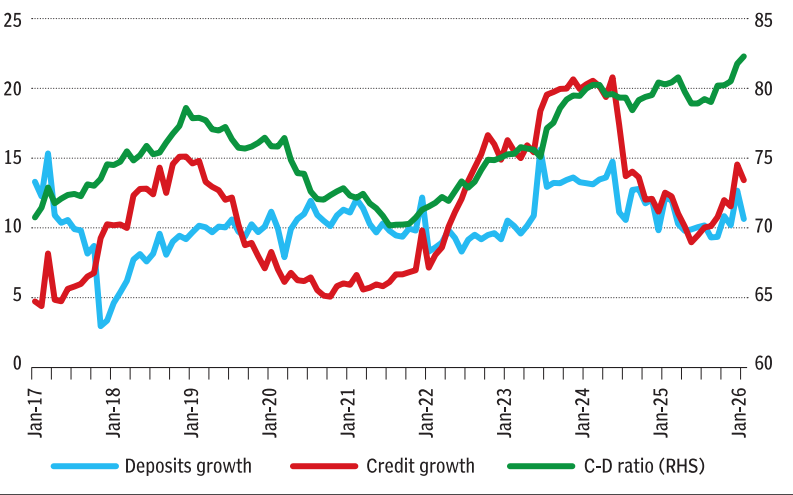
First, capital accumulation by banks have significantly increased. Changes in system level liquidity, as presented by annual M3 variation, is shown in Table 1. Asset side liquidity creation is mapped

Annual (y-o-y) variation in money stock (M₃) measures

Change	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
1. Liabilities						
1.1 Currency with the public	4,02,080 (17.5)	2,83,861 (15.3)	2,40,747 (9.4)	1,33,840 (4.1)	2,20,475 (5.5)	4,36,827 (9.0)
1.2 Deposits	16,33,690 (71.1)	13,54,199 (73.1)	15,89,967 (62.1)	23,37,242 (72.0)	22,15,725 (55.7)	37,13,543 (76.1)
1.3 ‘Other’ deposits with Reserve Bank	8,844 (0.4)	11,093 (0.6)	19,317 (0.8)	16,775 (0.5)	18,771 (0.5)	29,517 (0.6)
1.4 Banking sector’s net non-monetary liabilities	2,53,594 (11.0)	2,02,475 (10.9)	7,10,963 (27.8)	7,60,019 (23.4)	15,24,046 (38.3)	6,97,496 (14.3)
2. Assets						
2.1 Net bank credit to government	8,90,012 (38.7)	6,27,255 (33.9)	6,87,904 (26.9)	3,46,483 (10.7)	9,98,809 (25.1)	8,17,612 (16.8)
2.2 Bank credit to commercial sector	6,29,822 (27.4)	9,48,054 (51.2)	18,13,116 (70.8)	22,42,509 (69.1)	23,95,984 (60.2)	31,60,005 (64.8)
2.3 Net foreign exchange assets of banking sector	7,77,810 (33.8)	2,75,217 (14.9)	57,703 (2.3)	6,55,738 (20.2)	5,81,023 (14.6)	8,95,582 (18.4)
2.4 Government’s currency liabilities to the public	565 (0.0)	1,100 (0.1)	2,272 (0.1)	3,147 (0.1)	3,200 (0.1)	4,183 (0.1)
Total liabilities/assets	22,98,208 (100.0)	18,51,628 (100.0)	25,60,994 (100.0)	32,47,876 (100.0)	39,79,017 (100.0)	48,77,383 (100.0)

Source: RBI

Growth (y-o-y) in deposits, credit and CD ratio (%)



by the liabilities in the form of currency with the public, bank deposits (including both demand and time deposits), other deposits with RBI (mainly the CRR reserve), and the banking sector’s net monetary liabilities.

CHANGING LIABILITIES The changes in the banking sector’s net monetary liabilities since 2022 has been massive. Its contribution in the change increased from 11 per cent during 2021 and 2022 to 27.8 per cent in 2023, 23.4 per cent in 2024 and whopping 38.3 per cent in 2025.

Banks are keeping far higher capital buffer than prescribed by regulation and higher equity is substituting deposits for liquidity creation

Capital and reserve, or equity, of banks is the largest component of banking sector’s net monetary liabilities: Indian banks have accumulated large capital during this period. Thus, increase in deposits is substituted by increase in banks’ equity. The increase in banks’ equity is not just an allocation of household savings into stock market; it is specifically the move of savings to bank stocks.

The impact is amplified of course, by growing financialisation and digitalisation. Thus, additional equity by banks necessarily entails movement from deposit-like liquid claims toward equity, and in equilibrium market clearing requires that deposits will fall by the same amount: ‘new bank equity must come from somewhere’ (Gorton and Winton, 2017).

Second, banks are keeping far higher capital buffer than prescribed by regulation and higher equity is

West Asia crisis intensifies cost and supply risks

Auto components, ceramics, cement, among others are hit, but the sectoral impact is uneven. Bank credit may be impacted

K Ravichandran

Three months into the West Asia conflict, the geopolitical tensions are exerting a deeper influence on India’s economy.

Energy-intensive industries such as aviation, refining, fertilizers, and chemicals face the most pronounced challenges due to elevated input costs and operational disruptions. Aviation is under significant stress due to high aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices, airspace restrictions and weak demand. Limited fare pass-through, currency depreciation and rerouting inefficiencies will blot losses in FY27.

Raw material disruptions for key feedstocks, are constraining production for select chemicals and petrochemicals players. Limited pricing flexibility is compressing sales and margins across segments. Pressingly, elevated input costs and supply constraints in ammonia and sulphur are pressuring margins in the fertilizer sector, particularly for non-urea players, despite policy support mechanisms.

Additionally, ceramic tile exporters are faced with pressure from elevated

gas and fuel costs, straining revenues and compressing margins. Our channel checks suggest that smaller players are more exposed given their higher dependence on exports and weaker ability to absorb cost shocks. Domestic demand remains steady; however, exports to West Asia (20 per cent share) have been impacted, leading to a disproportionate effect on Morbi-based ceramic players given their higher reliance on overseas markets.

Elevated gold prices and duty hikes impose challenges for jewellery retail, moderating volumes and raising working capital needs despite stable supply and effective cost pass-through.

Several consumption-driven and export-oriented sectors are experiencing moderate headwinds through cost pressures and demand sensitivity. For instance, cement firms face margin pressure from higher input costs, including petcoke and diesel.

MODERATELY-HIT SECTORS Further, auto component players face moderate pressure from elevated raw material and fuel costs, though supply chains remain stable. Partial, lagged pass-through is leading to mild margin



ENERGY. Supply disruptions GETTY IMAGES

compression, while demand remains resilient despite risks from inflation and export softness. Tyre manufacturers face margin pressure from rising crude-linked inputs and limited pricing flexibility, alongside export disruptions and currency-related cost pressures.

For automobile Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEM), elevated commodity, freight and fuel costs will weaken margins, with pass-through remaining calibrated amid demand sensitivity in mass-market segments. While supply chains are broadly stable, any prolonged disruption could weigh on production planning and

affordability-led demand, especially in two-wheelers.

Additionally, quick Service Restaurants (QSR) operators face moderate disruption from LPG shortages.

Other sectors appear relatively less affected at present. Hospitality, pharmaceuticals, non-ferrous metals, textiles and cotton spinning remain relatively insulated, supported by diversified supply chains, captive availability of raw materials, domestic demand stability, or favourable pricing dynamics.

Nevertheless, the outlook is complicated by the sensitivity of financial sector profitability to asset quality. Rising economic stress could increase non-performing assets, especially in MSMEs and unsecured loans, amplifying the impact on bank profitability and credit growth.

In this challenging backdrop, we expect a significant moderation in the credit ratio, which is the ratio of rating upgrades to downgrades, in the current fiscal for India Inc, after buoyancy in the past 3-4 years.

The writer is Chief Rating Officer, ICRA

✉ LETTERS TO EDITOR Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Tata model This refers to the article “Tata Sons — should it be listed or remain unlisted?” (May 29). In its 165-year journey Tata Sons has expanded and succeeded in widely diversified industries from manufacturing and services to technology and exceeded shareholder expectations despite occasional hurdles. Thus, as an unlisted entity it has performed more like a listed company grounded in high ethics.

If we add its contribution in the fields of charity and social work, it comes up as a model business behemoth.

YG Chouksey Pune

Worthwhile proposal With reference to the Editorial “Fund of options” (May 29), keeping in view the growing investor interest in mutual fund SIP investments, SEBI’s proposal to ease the transactional convenience and structuring new investment tool is

timely and will instill confidence among the investor clan among employees. Through well-regulated contractual obligation between the employers, AMCs, depositories and payment enforcing banks, the scheme should perform well. However, the operational issues likely to emerge, could be from portability provisions for effective mandate enforcement in case of change of jobs by employees, passing on the commission, fair settlement

of final benefits to employees ensuring the income tax and capital gains tax deductions etc. This can be overcome by investor guidance to employers.

Sitaram Popuri Bengaluru

Handhold small farmers Apropos “Govt ready to face El Nino threat amid elusive monsoon” (May 29 BL290526). After an extreme summer that has dried-up major reservoirs and severe

groundwater depletion — the threat of El Nino combined with unpredictable monsoon is likely to affect the economics of the farmers who must be advised on monsoon deficient crop selection. Also dairy and livestock sectors must be provided with adequate facilities by supplying basic essentials like drinking water as most small and marginal farmers cannot afford to own deep wells.

Rajiv Magal Halekere Village (Karnataka)

QUICKLY.
Generali Central Life pegs
FY26 bonus at ₹102 crore



Hyderabad: Generali Central Life Insurance has announced a bonus of ₹102 crore for FY26, a 21 per cent growth from last year. The bonus declaration will benefit over 95,000 policies, reinforcing the company's commitment to delivering sustained value to policyholders. **OUR BUREAU**

Moody's upgrades
Tata Steel rating to Baa2

Mumbai: Moody's Ratings has upgraded Tata Steel issuer rating to Baa2 from Baa3. The rating reflects expectation of extraordinary support from its parent Tata Sons in a stress scenario. The stable outlook reflects our view that Tata Steel's earnings will strengthen and credit metrics will stay appropriate for the current rating, as the company progresses on its growth plans. **OUR BUREAU**

West Asia conflict likely to hit
Pipavav Port cargo volumes in Q1

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Gujarat Pipavav Port Ltd, operated by APM Terminals, expects a sharp shift in its cargo mix in the June quarter due to the ongoing West Asia conflict, with liquid cargo volumes likely to fall 35-40 per cent and bulk cargo volumes to decline 8-10 per cent sequentially.

The impact is mainly being driven by disruptions in shipping routes linked to West Asia, which has affected the movement of key commodities such as fertilisers and LPG at its port in Gujarat.

"We had seen a disruption of two services in March, out of which one is steadily performing. The other one continues to underperform which is West Asia Maersk service," Gujarat Pipavav Port Managing Director Girish Aggarwal said on Friday.

The disruption was most visible during



Gujarat Pipavav Port
MD Girish Aggarwal

March and April, particularly in fertilizer and LPG cargo flows.

"In terms of fertilizers — which largely comes out of West Asia — it was a challenge in March and April. But we are seeing fertilizers coming back both urea and other types of fertilizers," Aggarwal told investors.

"LPG was muted in March and April, but we are already starting to see growth. Now, a lot of LPG is starting to come from the US which has a longer travel time compared to West Asia," he added.

Despite the sharp fall expected in bulk and li-

quid cargo, the company expects container volumes to grow 5-7 per cent in the June quarter, supported by new shipping routes and shifting trade flows.

"There were certain opportunities we captured in April and May, which is West Asia transshipment cargo. So, that was an opportunity that presented itself to us and we captured it," Aggarwal said.

Container growth is also expected to be supported by Maersk's new F12 weekly service connecting Far East Asia with India, which includes Pipavav in its route network.

"Maersk has also announced a new service called F12 starting early July which will start calling Pipavav," he said.

The company said one of the disrupted shipping services has begun stabilising, though the West Asia Maersk feeder route remains affected.

'India needs \$180 b push to build a
competitive semicon ecosystem'

CRUCIAL ROADMAP. Partnerships are key to accelerate capability building, de-risk investments: NITI Aayog report

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Building a globally competitive semiconductor ecosystem in India will require nearly \$135-180 billion in cumulative semiconductor investment over the next decade, directed toward growth capital across design, fabrication, advanced packaging, materials and supporting infrastructure, said a NITI Aayog report released here on Friday.

The report suggested that the government should commit at least one-third of the required investment to de-risk projects and anchor long-term investor confidence.

The report, titled *Future of India's Semiconductor Industry*, said that building a globally competitive ecosystem is hard to achieve in isolation and therefore, deep, long-term partnerships are inevitable to build such ecosystems, complexity and



TECH DRIVE. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, I&B Minister Ashwini Vaisnaw and others during the launch of NITI Aayog Frontier Tech Hub's 'Future of India's Semiconductor Industry' in New Delhi on Friday.

capital intensity of the semiconductor value chain.

STRATEGIC TIES
"Partnerships are strategic instruments for India to accelerate capability building, de-risk investments and access frontier technologies. They can also integrate domestic industry into global semiconductor supply chains. What India needs is a partnership strategy that goes beyond transactional cooperation and is centred

on outcome-linked collaborations," it said.

The report noted that such partnerships should be designed to strengthen design capability, manufacturing scale, advanced packaging leadership, materials resilience and talent depth, aligned with the national roadmap to 2035.

According to the report, the country's semiconductor market is projected to reach around \$200 billion by 2035. However, despite the

growing domestic demand, nearly 90-95 per cent of this demand is currently met through imports, leading to large foreign exchange outflows and increasing the vulnerability of critical sectors to supply-chain disruptions.

"For India to become a developed nation, technological sovereignty is foundational. And that sovereignty must begin at the infrastructure layer. Semiconductors sit at the heart of this foundation, powering everything

from artificial intelligence (AI), defence and manufacturing to mobility, energy systems, communications and citizen services," Ashok Kumar Lahiri, Vice-Chairman, NITI Aayog, said.

SEMICON MARKET
The report also highlighted that the global semiconductor market grew at a compounded annual growth rate (CAGR) of 6.5 per cent between 2014 and 2024, and is expected to grow at a slightly higher CAGR of 8.5 per cent over the next five to 10 years, underpinned by next-generation, technology-led growth drivers.

"Parallel to the global semiconductor industry's rapid surge, India's semiconductor demand is also on an accelerated growth path. It is projected to grow at a CAGR of 19 per cent, reaching \$90 billion by FY2030 and potentially expanding further to over \$200 billion by FY2035 if this momentum continues," it added.

IIFCL's equity dilution gets govt nod

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The government has approved equity dilution in India Infrastructure Finance Company Ltd, said Rohit Rishi, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of the company, on Friday.

Meanwhile, the company reported a net profit of ₹1,379 crore in FY26 as against ₹1,590 crore of FY 25. The reduction is due to foreign exchange loss.

"Equity dilution expected to be in two tranches to bring down government's equity to 75 per cent," Rishi said in a briefing here. However, the timing of IPO has not been finalised. "It will be done at opportune time," Rishi added.

INFRA FINANCING
He also highlighted that the while total infrastructure financing is estimated at ₹38,000 crore, out of which approximately ₹500 crore will be towards social infrastruc-



Rohit Rishi, MD& CEO, IIFCL

ture. "We have got some proposal for hospitals. Also, some project for educational institutional will be there," he said without disclosing details about the projects.

Meanwhile, talking about financial performance for FY26, he said its performance reflects its ongoing institutional consolidation, prudent financial management, and growing scale as a future-ready infrastructure financing institution. The company remains firmly aligned with India's long-term development priorities, con-

tinuing to play a pivotal role in powering the nation's infrastructure growth journey through resilience and sustained business expansion.

Rishi highlighted highest-ever sanctions which reflects growing infrastructure financing footprint. The company recorded its highest-ever annual sanctions of ₹57,680 crore during FY26, which is around 13 per cent higher over the previous year. Annual disbursements increased 16 per cent to ₹32,972 crore.

IIFCL's net worth rose to ₹17,898 crore in FY26 from ₹16,395 crore in the previous year, reflecting continued strengthening of its capital base and lending capacity. IIFCL maintained a capital to risk-weighted assets ratio of 20.53 per cent as of March 31, 2026 — well above regulatory requirements. Gross NPA ratio improving sharply to 0.40 per cent from 1.11 per cent in the previous year, while net NPA ratio reduced to 0 per cent.

Maharashtra will provide
innovators access to
2,000 GPUs, says CM

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Maharashtra government will provide access to 2,000 GPUs to innovators to help develop and train AI models, said Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis at the Mumbai Tech Week event on Friday.

Addressing the group of start-up founders in the city, Fadnavis said, "Today, we talk in terms of GPUs. If the innovators cannot afford computing facility then the innovation stops at that. So, we are also creating compute-as-a-service facility by which we will make available 2,000 GPUs to all innovators so that they can have direct access to it."

Fadnavis argued that there is an appetite and an ecosystem in the State that will lead the AI revolution.

Further he said investors and start-ups are resolving their confusion on whether to stay in Mumbai or go to any other city as the city has become "the start-up capital of India by sheer numbers and also by investment."

DEDICATED INFRA
Fadnavis also talked about plans to attract ₹10,000 crore in investments, create 125 lakh jobs and build dedicated infrastructure to support start-ups and innova-



We have created a very robust policy whereby we look at ₹10,000 crore investment in AI, 125 lakh jobs being created

DEVENDRA FADNAVIS
Chief Minister, Maharashtra

tion in the sector, under its recent AI policy. Further, it plans to set up six Centres of Excellence focused on AI and create dedicated AI Innovation Regions to encourage research, development and commercialisation.

"We have created a very robust policy whereby we look at ₹10,000 crore investment in AI, 125 lakh jobs being created. We want to create six centres of excellence around AI. We are going to create AI innovation regions," he said.

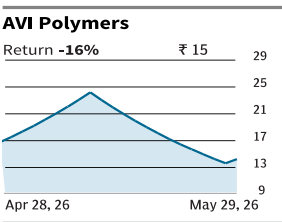
		ITI LIMITED				
CIN No: L32202KA1950G0100640						
Registered & Corporate Office: ITI Bhavan, Doorvaninagar, Bengaluru-560016 Website: www.itiitd.in; Email: cosecy_crp@itiitd.co.in Tel: +91 (80) 2561 7486; Fax: +91 (80) 2561 7525						
Statement of Consolidated Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and Year Ended 31st March 2026						
		₹ in Lakhs except per share data				
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Year Ended	
		31-03-2026	31-12-2025	31-03-2025	31-03-2026	31-03-2025
		Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited	Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	62,765	51,465	104,570	218,372	361,642
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	(8,368)	(2,101)	(6,726)	(15,636)	(26,819)
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	(8,368)	(2,101)	(6,726)	(15,636)	(26,819)
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	37,514	(2,533)	(438)	29,283	(21,489)
5	Other comprehensive Income/(Loss) for the period	-	-	-	(849)	(392)
6	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)	37,514	(2,533)	(438)	28,434	(21,881)
7	Paid up Equity Share Capital	96,285	96,285	96,089	96,285	96,089
8	Other Equity (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in Audited balance sheet of previous year	94,278	-	66,369	94,278	66,369
9	Earnings Per Share (of ₹10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)					
	1. Basic: (In ₹)	3.90	(0.26)	(0.05)	3.04	(2.24)
	2. Diluted: (In ₹)	3.90	(0.26)	(0.05)	3.04	(2.24)
Note:						
a) The above financial results were reviewed by the Audit Committee on 28.05.2026 and upon its recommendations were approved by the Board of Directors at their meeting held on 28.05.2026						
b) Key Standalone Financial information:						
	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Year Ended	
		31-03-2026	31-12-2025	31-03-2025	31-03-2026	31-03-2025
		Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited	Audited
	Total Income from Operations	62,765	51,465	104,570	218,372	361,642
	Profit before tax	37,536	(2,558)	(484)	29,279	(23,314)
	Profit after tax	37,536	(2,558)	(484)	29,279	(23,314)
	Other comprehensive Income/(Loss) for the period	-	-	-	(849)	(392)
	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)	37,536	(2,558)	(484)	28,430	(23,706)
c) The above is an extract of the detailed format of Financial Results for the year ended 31st March 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and year ended 31st March 2026 are available on the BSE Limited website at www.bseindia.com and National Stock Exchange of India Limited website at www.nseindia.com and on the Company's website at www.itiitd.in .						
By Order of the Board For ITI Limited						
C V Ramana Babu Director Finance & CFO						
Place : Bengaluru Date : 29.05.2026						

POLYSPIN EXPORTS LIMITED					
CIN : L51909TN1985PLC011683					
Regd. Office : No.351, P.A.C.R. Salai, RAJAPALAYAM - 626 117.					
E-mail : fibc@polyspin.in Website : www.polyspin.org					
EXTRACT OF AUDITED STANDALONE FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31 ST MARCH, 2026 (Rs. in Lakhs)					
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended		Year ended	
		Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited
		31.03.2026	31.12.2025	31.03.2025	31.03.2026
1	Total Income from Continuing Operations (Net)	5,706.55	5,473.12	6,116.97	22,963.28
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax from Continuing Operations	68.40	83.58	101.18	490.99
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax from Continuing Operations	50.35	60.60	43.52	390.04
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax from Discontinued Operations	-	-	-	-
5	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax from Discontinued Operations	-	-	-	-
6	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax	50.35	60.60	43.52	390.04
7	Total Comprehensive Income for the period after tax (Comprising Net Profit for the Period after tax and other Comprehensive Income after tax)	29.12	62.34	157.23	384.62
8	Equity Share Capital (Face Value of Rs. 5/- each)	500.00	500.00	500.00	500.00
9	Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve)	--	--	--	5,442.46
10	Basic & Diluted Earnings per Share of Rs.5/- each (in Rs.) Not Annualized	0.50	0.61	0.44	3.90
- From Continuing Operations		-	-	-	-
- From Discontinued Operations		-	-	-	-
- From Continuing and Discontinued Operations		0.50	0.61	0.44	3.90
EXTRACT OF AUDITED CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31 ST MARCH, 2026 (Rs. in Lakhs)					
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended		Year ended	
		Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited
		31.03.2026	31.12.2025	31.03.2025	31.03.2026
1	Total Income from Continuing Operations (Net)	5,706.55	5,461.92	6,105.68	22,952.08
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax from Continuing Operations	66.97	72.38	138.61	656.57
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax from Continuing Operations	48.91	49.40	80.95	555.62
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax from Discontinued Operations	-	-	-	-
5	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax from Discontinued Operations	-	-	-	-
6	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax	48.91	49.40	80.95	555.62
7	Total Comprehensive Income for the period after tax (Comprising Net Profit for the Period after tax and other Comprehensive Income after tax)	27.68	126.34	194.66	550.20
8	Equity Share Capital (Face Value of Rs. 5/- each)	500.00	500.00	500.00	500.00
9	Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve)	--	--	-	6,461.75
10	Basic & Diluted Earnings per Share of Rs.5/- each (in Rs.) Not Annualized	0.49	1.25	0.81	5.56
- From Continuing Operations		-	-	-	-
- From Discontinued Operations		-	-	-	-
- From Continuing and Discontinued Operations		0.49	1.25	0.81	5.56
Note :					
The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarter and year ended financial results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarter and year ended financial results are available on the Stock Exchange Website at www.bseindia.com and on the Company's website at www.polyspin.org .					
Place : Rajapalayam Date : May 29, 2026		By order of the Board of Directors For POLYSPIN EXPORTS LIMITED -sd- DURGAM RAMJI MANAGING DIRECTOR			

Sakthi Finance				
SINCE 1955				
SAKTHI FINANCE LIMITED				
CIN : L65910TJ1955PLC000145				
Regd. Office : 62, Dr.Nanjappa Road, Coimbatore - 641 018				
Tel : (0422) 4236200; Fax : (0422) 2231915				
E-mail : investors@sakthifinance.com; Website : www.sakthifinance.com				
NOTICE TO DEBENTURE HOLDERS				
Redemption and Payment of Interest due on Public Issue of Secured and Unsecured, Redeemable, Non-Convertible Debentures ("NCDs") issued in terms of Prospectus dated 13 June 2024 and 25 June 2021 respectively				
Notice is hereby given that the Company has fixed Wednesday, 24 June 2026 and Friday, 14 August 2026 as Record Dates for redemption of NCDs of ₹1,000 each under Options I and II of Public Issue 2024 and Options VII and VIII of Public Issue 2021 along with interest, as applicable, issued and allotted as per the Prospectus dated 13 June 2024 and 25 June 2021 respectively for determining the names of the debenture holders who are eligible to receive redemption and interest proceeds.				
1. SECURED NCDs ALLOTTED ON 9 JULY 2024				
Option	ISIN	Scrip Code	Interest payment frequency	Redemption details
I	INE302E07748	939599	Monthly*	100 per cent of the principal amount plus interest for the month of July 2026 (i.e. up to 8 July 2026) will be paid along with the redemption proceeds as per the terms and conditions of the Prospectus dated 13 June 2024 on Thursday, 9 July 2026 .
II	INE302E07763	939601	Cumulative*	100 per cent of the principal amount plus accrued interest up to 8 July 2026 (i.e. for 2 years) will be paid along with redemption proceeds as per the terms and conditions of the Prospectus dated 13 June 2024 on Thursday, 9 July 2026 .
2. UNSECURED NCDs ALLOTTED ON 29 JULY 2021				
Option	ISIN	Scrip Code	Interest payment frequency	Redemption details
VII	INE302E08084	937595	Monthly*	100 per cent of the principal amount plus interest for the month of August 2026 (i.e. up to 28 August 2026) will be paid along with the redemption proceeds as per the terms and conditions of the Prospectus dated 25 June 2021 on Saturday, 29 August 2026 .
VIII	INE302E08092	937597	Cumulative*	100 per cent of the principal amount plus accrued interest up to 28 August 2026 (i.e. for 61 months) will be paid along with redemption proceeds as per the terms and conditions of the Prospectus dated 25 June 2021 on Saturday, 29 August 2026 .
*subject to deduction of tax, wherever applicable.				
The Debenture Holders who have debentures in demat / electronic mode and whose names stand as the beneficial owners on the Record Dates as per the list provided by the Depositories on Wednesday, 24 June 2026 and Friday, 14 August 2026 respectively, would be entitled to the redemption payments.				
Debenture holders who hold debentures in electronic form are also requested to lodge mandate instructions, change in bank account details, Income Tax Exemption Certificate / forms and change of address intimation, etc. as may be applicable, with their respective Depository Participants ("DP") on or before 3 days from the record dates i.e. 24 June 2026 and 14 August 2026 respectively.				
For Sakthi Finance Limited S. Venkatesh 29 May 2026 Coimbatore - 18 Company Secretary and Chief Compliance Officer FCS 7012				

QUICKLY.

AVI Polymers to consider stock-split, bonus issue



Mumbai: AVI Polymers, a listed polymer manufacturer with a growing focus on technology driven businesses, has announced that its board of directors will meet on Thursday to consider strategic proposals aimed at enhancing shareholder value and strengthening the company's future growth roadmap. The board will evaluate a proposed stock-split of equity shares up to a ratio of 1:10 and a bonus issue of equity shares up to a ratio of 10:1. The company will also consider its proposed entry into green technology and sustainability-focused business segments. The proposed stock-split is intended to improve liquidity in the capital market and make the company's equity shares more accessible to a wider base of retail investors. OUR BUREAU

SEBI okays Upma Chowdhry as MSE Chairperson

Mumbai: The Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India (MSE) said on Friday that SEBI has approved the appointment of Upma Dada Chowdhry as the Chairperson of its governing board. Prior to taking on this role, Chowdhry served as a Public Interest Director at the exchange. She brings more than 35 years of extensive administrative and governance expertise to the position. A 1983-batch Indian Administrative Service officer of the Himachal Pradesh cadre, she had previously retired as a Secretary to the Government of India. Her career spans crucial sectors including finance, public sector reforms, education, and women's empowerment. OUR BUREAU

BROKER'S CALL.

Anand Rathi Research

FINOLEX INDUSTRIES (BUY)

Target: ₹240
CMP: ₹185.95
Finolex Industries delivered a mixed performance in Q4FY26. Its revenue missed our estimate by 8.9 per cent on lower pipe volume of -0.5 per cent year on year vs. ARe of 10 per cent, due to weak demand for agri pipes. The company appears to have again lost market share in Q4FY26, as it posted marginally negative pipe volume growth vs. healthy positive volume growth reported by its major peers.
The agri pipe volume was down 3 per cent, while non-agri pipe volume grew 6 per cent. However, its EBITDA sharply exceeded our estimate by 51.8 per cent driven by 1,065 bps rise in margin to 25.3 per cent vs. our estimate of 15.2 per cent, led by MTM inventory gain (₹35-40 crore) and better-mix.
The management has guided for high-single to low-double-digit volume growth with sub-15 per cent EBITDA margin for FY27.
The company targets to increase the share of non-agri pipe to 50 per cent over the next four-five years from 37 per cent in FY26. The company does not have any major growth capex plan for FY27, as the management believes the current production capacity (520 ktpa) can cater to the near-term growth requirement. Budgeted capex is estimated at ₹100-200 crore for FY27e.
Considering soft volume in Q4FY26, we have slightly trimmed our EPS estimates by 4.6 per cent/0.1 per cent for FY27/28E. We maintain BUY rating on the stock with an unrevised TP of ₹240, valuing it at an unchanged multiple 20x FY27/28E EPS.

HDFC Securities

ALKEM LABORATORIES (ADD)

Target: ₹6,230
CMP: ₹5,497.80
Alkem Laboratories' EBITDA grew 32 per cent year on year, led by 15 per cent sales growth, higher gross margin (65.9 per cent), offset by higher costs (staff/R&D/SG&A +16 per cent/45 per cent/28 per cent).
The company expects: India business to beat IPM growth by 100-150 bps in FY27, led by increasing share from chronic share (about 22 per cent in FY26), scale-up in Semaglutide (GLP-1) franchisee, traction from key therapies and new launches; its MR addition (about 14,500 in FY26) will remain strategic with focus on chronic business; to remain cautious on near-term gross and EBITDA margin due to cost escalations (input materials like APIs/packaging, and logistics — SG&A to see 7-8 per cent growth in FY27E), led by geopolitical issue, its targets to improve EBITDA margin by 100 bps per annum for the next few years; the US business to see high-single-digit growth, led by new launches (expects launch of Tolvaptan in H2FY27E); International export formulations to see high-teen growth over the next few years; and R&D at 4-5 per cent of sales and ETR to be at 27-28 per cent vs earlier guidance of 33-35 per cent.
Factoring in the FY26 performance, outlook and lower ETR, we have raised our EPS by 2 per cent/6 per cent for FY27/28E and revised the TP to ₹6,230 (28x FY28E EPS). ADD stays as we expect the India business to remain steady and the US business to scale up along with steady margin improvement.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

Sensex crashes over 1,000 points as MSCI rejig sparks heavy selloff

WEAK SENTIMENT. Barring the Nifty IT index, all sectoral indices closed in the red on a tumultuous day

Anupama Ghosh Mumbai

The markets closed sharply lower on Friday, with a near 300-point freefall in the final 30 minutes of trade wiping out most of the day's gains, as MSCI's May 2026 index rebalancing triggered an estimated \$800 million to \$1 billion in passive foreign outflows from Indian equities. Federal Bank, MCX, NALCO and Indian Bank were added to the MSCI Standard Index, while Rail Vikas Nigam, Kalyan Jewellers, Jubilant FoodWorks and Hyundai Motor India were removed. "The pressure intensified during the final hours of trade after the MSCI Global

Standard Index rebalancing came into effect, triggering heightened volatility in select stocks amid expected passive fund flow adjustments," said Siddhartha Khemka, Motilal Oswal Financial Services.

FIRM OPENING

The markets had opened on a firm note after reports emerged that the US and Iran had reached a preliminary agreement to extend their ceasefire by 60 days and ease shipping restrictions through the Strait of Hormuz.

The Nifty briefly touched 24,002 before selling pressure at that psychological level triggered a reversal. The Sensex declined 1,092 points to settle at 74,775,



BEARISH MOVES. There was a near 300-point freefall in the final 30 minutes of trade, wiping out most of the day's gains

while the Nifty 50 tumbled 359 points to close at 23,547. Heavy selling in Reliance Industries, down over 1.6 per cent, and ITC, down over 3

per cent, along with weakness in banking majors HDFC Bank and ICICI Bank, deepened the decline. Barring the Nifty IT index,

Nomination process for demat a/cs, MFs simplified

Our Bureau Mumbai

SEBI has eased the nomination norms for demat accounts and mutual fund folios, simplifying the process for investors while making nomination the default option for all new single-holder accounts opened from September 1.

The new rules will apply to both new and existing accounts and folios.

In a circular issued on Friday, the regulator said investors opening single-holder demat accounts or MF folios will have to mandatorily provide nomination details unless they specifically choose to opt out through a declaration form.



Joint accounts, however, will continue to have optional nomination facilities.

The move comes after the regulator received representations from market participants citing operational challenges in implementing earlier nomination rules issued in January 2025.

REVISED FRAMEWORK

Under the revised framework, investors can nominate up to three individuals. In

cases involving multiple nominees, the holdings can either continue in the same account after the investor's demise or be split into separate accounts or folios based on respective entitlements.

SEBI has also relaxed procedural requirements for physical nominations. Witness signatures will no longer be required if the investor signs the nomination form with a regular signature. Witnesses will be mandatory only in cases where the investor uses a thumb impression.

The regulator has allowed both online and offline modes for nominations. Online nominations can be authenticated using digital signatures, Aadhaar-based e-sign, other legally-recog-

nised e-sign facilities or two-factor authentication involving a one-time password sent to the investor's registered mobile number and email address.

The regulator has reduced the mandatory information required for nomination to only the nominee's name and relationship with the investor. Details such as mobile number, email address, share allocation among nominees and identity documents have been made optional.

Where investors do not specify percentage allocations among nominees, the holdings will be divided equally, with any residual odd lot transferred to the first nominee listed in the form.

'Mid-, small-cap earnings growth keeps broader market outlook for FY27 positive'

Madhu Balaji Bengaluru

The benchmark indices may have remained in consolidation mode over the past few months, but strong earnings growth in the broader market continues to keep medium- to long-term opportunities intact, according to Ankit Patel, Co-founder and Partner, Arunasset Investment Services.

"Consolidation has removed excesses, especially in the broader market. In terms of index valuations, we're broadly close to historical averages," Patel said. "The earnings growth, however in the small- and mid-cap space is, in our view, going to beat expectations."

He said the Nifty Midcap 150 and Nifty Smallcap 250 delivered close to 30 per cent year-on-year EPS growth in Q4, while brokerage estimates are factoring in over 25 per cent earnings growth for smaller companies in FY27.

He added that actively managed and concentrated strategies are likely to outperform, as opportunities remain increasingly stock-spe-

cific rather than index-driven.

MID-CAPS RALLY

Patel said the rally in the Nifty Midcap 100 had largely been earnings-led rather than purely valuation-driven. "The PE has risen sharply but the denominator E has also supported," Patel said. "Q4 results show this clearly. Mid-cap earnings growth has been around 30 per cent year-on-year, which gives the rally a stronger fundamental base."

He added that concentrated and actively managed strategies such as PMS products and actively-managed small- and mid-cap funds are likely to outperform over the medium term.

Strong domestic institutional investor (DII) participation has been one of the biggest drivers of market resilience, Patel said. According to him, DIIs bought ₹2.09 lakh crore worth of equities during Q3 FY26, averaging nearly ₹70,000 crore per month. Following the February 28 market correction, DIIs turned even more aggressive and bought ₹1.43 lakh crore in March alone.



Ankit Patel, Co-founder and Partner, Arunasset Investment Services

"This shows that large domestic investors did not panic when uncertainty spiked; they used the correction to deploy capital," Patel said.

He added that DII buying moderated to ₹51,064 crore in April after the markets rebounded sharply, with the Nifty 50 rising 7.5 per cent, the Nifty Midcap 100 gaining 13.6 per cent and the Nifty Smallcap 100 advancing 18.4 per cent during the month.

INVESTOR SENTIMENT

"This suggests investors were aggressive when prices were lower and more measured after the rebound," Patel said.

Suzlon Energy, executives fined for misleading finances

Our Bureau Mumbai

The SEBI has imposed penalties totalling nearly ₹29 crore on Suzlon Energy and four former executives after finding that a series of intra-group transactions had created a misleading picture of the wind turbine maker's financial health.

In a detailed order, the capital markets regulator fined Suzlon Energy ₹15.95 crore, while penalties of ₹5.75 crore and ₹5.45 crore were levied on former Chairman Vinod R Tanti and Vice-Chairman Girish R Tanti, respectively. Former executives Kirti J Vagadia and Amit Agarwal were fined ₹1.5 crore and ₹30 lakh. The regulator also set aside an earlier June 2025 adjudication order that had exonerated the company and its officials.

The case relates to transactions undertaken between

FY14 and FY21 involving Suzlon and several subsidiaries, including the transfer of its operations and maintenance services (OMS) business to Suzlon Global Services in 2014.

OMS TRANSFER

According to SEBI, the OMS business, which had a book value of ₹77.08 crore, was transferred for ₹2,000 crore, enabling Suzlon to recognise an exceptional gain of ₹1,922.92 crore. The regulator said the company subsequently booked another gain of ₹829.78 crore through an intra-group transfer of stake in the subsidiary. SEBI held that a portion of the sale consideration was routed through circular transactions between the company and its subsidiaries. It said these transactions artificially inflated Suzlon's net worth and reduced reported losses in its financial statements.

Motilal Oswal Private Wealth neutral on equities, sees opportunity in broader markets

Our Bureau Bengaluru

and the firm has maintained an 'Overweight' stance on the mid- and small-cap segment to capture this relative resilience.

PORTFOLIO MIX

In its latest Alpha Strategist report for May 2026, the brokerage suggested a structured portfolio allocation consisting of 50 per cent in hybrid or large-caps, 40 per cent in mid- and small-caps and 10 per cent in global exposure. It maintained a 'Neutral' view on the broader equity market but recommended a staggered approach for pure equity-oriented strategies.

It maintained a neutral allocation stance on gold and silver

with more weight towards gold, supported by continued central bank buying and easing speculative excess in global gold markets.

"Global markets in 2026 are increasingly being shaped by AI-led earnings and infrastructure cycle, with technology heavy economies such as South Korea and Taiwan leading the up-cycle, while India continues to demonstrate resilience through its strong domestic macroeconomic fundamentals," said Ashish Shanker, MD and CEO, Motilal Oswal Private Wealth, adding that record GST collections and signs of rural recovery are pillars of the domestic investment-led growth story.

SC sets aside order directing RIL to disgorge ₹447 crore

Press Trust of India New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday set aside an order directing Reliance Industries (RIL) to disgorge ₹447.27 crore in a matter relating to the trading of Reliance Petroleum (RPL) shares in 2007.

The court partly allowed the appeal filed by RIL challenging a November 2020 order of the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT), Mumbai.

The SAT, by a 2:1 majority order, dismissed RIL's appeal against the SEBI's March 24, 2017, order relating to the sale of RPL shares in November 2007. The top court said the SAT committed an "egregious error" in passing the judgment insofar as the question of fraud under Regulations 3 and 4 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Prohibition of Fraudulent and Unfair Trade Practices relating to Securities Market), 2003, (PFUTP) is concerned.

The bench said it had no other option but to set aside the November 5, 2020, order passed by the SAT concerning the finding of fraud under the PFUTP regulations.

CIAL COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LTD
T.C - 29/4016, Women's College-Bakery Junction Road, Vazhuthacaud, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, India - 695014.
Tel.: +91 471 2252855, 2320089 email: kcb@keralacashewboard.com
No: KCB/73/360/2026/GB(14) Date: 20.05.2026
E-TENDER NOTICE
Kerala Cashew Board Limited invites e-tenders through e-procurement portal for the import of 2000 - 5000 Metric Tonnes of quality **Dried Raw Cashew Nut of 2026 crop of Guinea Bissau origin**, with the following quality specifications on import basis.
(Tender ID:- 2026_KCBI_851994_1)
Outturn : 53 lbs. per 80 Kg bag Nut Count : 220 Numbers per Kg
Last date for submission and uploading e-tenders : 1700 hours on 29th June 2026
Opening of e-tender : 1100 hours on 30th June 2026
All details can be viewed, downloaded and applied through the e-procurement portal www.etenders.kerala.gov.in
CHAIRMAN & MANAGING DIRECTOR

KERALA CASHEW BOARD LIMITED (KCB)
T.C - 29/4016, Women's College-Bakery Junction Road, Vazhuthacaud, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, India - 695014.
Tel.: +91 471 2252855, 2320089 email: kcb@keralacashewboard.com
No: KCB/73/360/2026/GB(14) Date: 20.05.2026
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CHAIRMAN & MANAGING DIRECTOR

NATCO Pharma Limited
Regd. Office: Natco House, Road No.2, Banjara Hills, Hyderabad-500 034, Phone: 040-23547532, Email: investors@natcopharma.co.in CIN: L24230TG1981PLC003201, www.natcopharma.co.in
STATEMENT OF AUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026
Based on the recommendations of the Audit Committee, the Board of Directors of the Company at their meeting held on May 29, 2026, have approved the audited standalone and consolidated financial results for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026.
The above mentioned financial results along with press release thereon are available on Company's website at <https://admin.natcopharma.co.in/wp-content/uploads/2026/05/OutcomeofBM29052026.pdf> and also at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com
Scan the Quick Response (QR) code access the FY 26 Results

for NATCO PHARMA LIMITED
Sd/-
Place: Hyderabad V C Nannapaneni
Date: 29.05.2026 Chairman & Managing Director

Forex exposure, fleet strategy in focus as IndiGo charts flight path for FY27

BALANCE SHEET WOES. Foreign exchange volatility remains biggest challenge, says InterGlobe Aviation

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Foreign exchange volatility continues to remain one of the biggest risks for IndiGo, said the airline's parent company, InterGlobe Aviation.

As per the company, every ₹1 movement against the US dollar translates into nearly ₹900 crore of balance sheet impact for the airline.

Speaking during an analyst call following the company's Q4FY26 earnings announcement, the airline's management said IndiGo's total foreign exchange exposure currently stands at nearly \$10 billion, of which around \$1.3 billion has been hedged.

According to the airline's CFO Gaurav Negi, the airline will continue evaluating opportunities to increase hedging coverage going forward.



STRATEGIC SHIFT. Owing aircraft instead of leasing them will help the airline reduce lease-related costs

Besides, the management said excess cash beyond the airline's 20-25 per cent revenue safety net, estimated at around ₹20,000-25,000 crore, will be utilised to acquire aircraft outright.

CUTTING LEASE COSTS Furthermore, he cited that owning aircraft instead of leasing them will help the airline reduce lease-related costs as well as lower foreign exchange exposure.

Answering another question, Negi said the airline's immediate priority is returning expensive damp leases

and phasing out older fuel-inefficient aircraft, including A320 CEOs, while maintaining existing aircraft delivery schedules.

Meanwhile, the airline expects the number of grounded aircraft to reduce from the current levels in the 40s to the 30s in the coming months.

He also said the airline has been actively increasing fares to offset rising costs, though fuel surcharge increases have not yet fully compensated for the rise in fuel costs.

As per the management,

IndiGo expects mid-teen unit revenue growth during the first quarter of FY27, partly aided by fuel surcharge adjustments and a favourable base effect.

He added that the airline expects full restoration of the affected international capacity by the end of June.

Additionally, the airline expects capacity addition in the Indian market to be around 3-4 per cent year-on-year during the first quarter of FY27. "Our readiness in FDTL is complete and will remain so in the future," the airline's Managing Director Rahul Bhatia said, referring to flight duty time limitation norms.

CORE STRATEGY

Responding to a query regarding the role of Willie Walsh at IndiGo, Bhatia said the airline's single-aisle aircraft programme centred around A320 and A321 air-

craft will continue to remain core to the company's long-term strategy.

"Our single aisle programme (A320s/A321s) will always be central to the future of the company. We are adding mutations with XLRs and A350s — that will be the hybrid model and that is something Willie Walsh is experienced in," Bhatia said.

"While we widen our international footprint, we will protect our core domestic business," he added.

The airline ended FY26 with a total cash balance of ₹51,650.6 crore, including free cash of ₹36,216.3 crore.

In addition, InterGlobe Aviation said total debt, including capitalised operating lease liabilities, stood at ₹77,749.2 crore.

As of March 31, 2026, IndiGo operated a fleet of 441 aircraft and provided services to 97 domestic and 45 international destinations.

Happiest Minds sees strong FY27, confident of 12.5% revenue growth

bl.interview

Sanjana B
Bengaluru



AI engagements are increasingly outcome-based, because clients are not going to pay merely for effort or presence

VENKATRAMAN NARAYANAN
Managing Director



We have 2-3 large customers in that (GCC) region, and we're seeing a continued uptick in demand. I feel quite bullish about it

JOSEPH ANANTHARAJU
Co-Chairman, CEO

Happiest Minds reported Q4 FY26 total income of ₹621.7 crore, up 3.1 per cent quarter-on-quarter (q-o-q) and 9 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y). Meanwhile, profit after tax (PAT) rose sharply to ₹61.2 crore, up 51.8 per cent q-o-q and 79.9 per cent y-o-y. Adjusted PAT stood at ₹71.4 crore, up 2.1 per cent q-o-q and 21.3 per cent y-o-y. For the full year FY26, revenue stood at ₹2,315.1 crore, up 12.3 per cent y-o-y, while PAT increased 15.1 per cent y-o-y to ₹212.6 crore. Joseph Anantharaju, Co-Chairman and CEO, and Venkatraman Narayanan, Managing Director, spoke about the company's AI strategy, sectoral outlook and growth expectations for FY27.

Edited excerpts:

What are key takeaways from the Q4FY26 performance?

VN: For the year, we have shown dollar growth of about 9.2 per cent compared to our guidance of 10 per cent. Our operating margin level was 17.5 per cent. It was a good year and a good foundation for the next year. We have guided 12.5 per cent growth for the next year and are well-positioned to achieve it. Next year's growth will be the basis for aspirational growth of about 15 per cent the year after. Some have observed that 12.5 per cent growth appears somewhat higher than the industry. Several mid-sized firms in the \$1-2 billion range are growing at over 15 per cent. There is no reason why we should not be able to achieve similar growth.

What proportion of FY26 growth came from existing customers versus new client additions?

VN: Repeat business is about 93 per cent. As of the halfway point, our run rate for the year was \$19 million. The definition of 'new' differs

from a sales perspective and a reporting perspective. From a sales standpoint, a salesperson retains ownership of a new customer for 18 months. For reporting purposes, customers added outside the rolling 12-month period accounted for about 7 per cent.

JA: The total number of customers or logos increased by around 51 per cent during the year.

Could you share a breakdown of revenues coming from AI-linked projects?

VN: We created GBS as a separate business unit even before the broader AI wave accelerated. Today, it contributes 3.3 per cent of our revenues, and everything it does is AI-led, since it was established as an AI innovation centre. At the same time, over the last 18 months, AI has become embedded across almost everything we do. AI is now part of software development, and 6-7 of our repeatable solutions across PDES and IMSS are AI-enabled, or AI-driven offerings created either directly by GBS or with its contribution.

We will come out with a number for contributions from AI-led services. It's only a matter of the next quarter or a few months.

Another important point is that many people assess AI revenues based on contract structures such as time-and-materials or fixed-price models. However, AI-led work should be evaluated through an outcome-based lens. There is often confusion between pricing structures and contract models. Even if a large share of business is AI-led, the contract model may still formally remain TNM or FP. But AI engagements themselves are increasingly outcome-based, because clients are not going to pay merely for effort or presence.

Have geopolitical tensions in the GCC affected client decision-making or discretionary tech spending in any way?

VN: We're seeing a large deal coming from the region, which contributes almost \$13-14 million.

JA: We have 2-3 large customers in that region, and we're seeing a continued uptick in demand. I feel quite bullish about the region.

We haven't seen any impact in terms of discretionary spending. But if the conflict drags on for too long, at some point, it may be the straw that breaks the camel's back. We're hoping there's a resolution in the near future.

63SATS Cybertech expects high demand for AI-aided defences

Our Bureau
Mumbai

63SATS Cybertech, the cybersecurity arm of 63 moons technologies, expects a surge in corporate demand for services to comply with the stiff Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act and AI-powered cybersecurity defences.

With the new legislation rollout slated for May 2027, India Inc has been buckling up as non-compliance with the DPDP Act and data breaches carry heavy penalties of up to ₹250 crore per incident.

SECURITY SAFEGUARDS

The comprehensive privacy legislation DPDP Act balances the rights of individuals to protect their personal data with the need for lawful data processing. It mandates clear consent, strong security safeguards and introduces heavy penalties for data breaches.

Srinivas L, Joint MD and Joint CEO, 63SATS Cybertech, in an interaction with *businessline* said the recent cyberattacks on public institutions such as mutual fund houses and educational institutions have exposed the vulnerability of IT infrastructure.

The advent of AI has made it more easier for hackers to break into any secured servers and create a havoc, he said.

On the flip-side, he added any threat can be dealt with as time to analyse a threat has been reduced to just 20 seconds with AI from two hours, he said.



63SATS Cybertech has zeroed in on DPDP Act compliance services alongside AI security as its core business drivers.

The cybersecurity firm has partnered with leading DPDP solutions providers such as IDfy, GoTrust, RNR and Qila.io. The company also offer a five-day free DPDP gap assessment to corporates who are required to be DPDP-compliant, said Srinivas.

MULTIPLE SPECIALISTS

"The Act is so comprehensive that it needs multiple specialists to work on each segments," he said.

63SATS Cybertech offers an end-to-end, operational privacy architecture rather than a point-in-time framework, guiding organisations

through a continuous four-stage lifecycle of assessing, designing, implementing and monitoring. The company's enterprise solution CyberSecurity Force implements continuous, automated AI-based red-teaming and an AI CyberOps model within its security operations centre.

This infrastructure is aimed at addressing today's compressed threat timelines, where vulnerability exploits develop within 72 hours.

FLAGSHIP APP

Further, it also mitigates 'shadow AI' internal data leaks by deploying private large language models (LLMs) with role-based access control.

The company's flagship mobile application CYBX operates as a cybersecurity super-app that also features customised cyber fraud insurance of up to ₹10 lakh underwritten by ICICI Lombard

63SATS Cybertech focuses on delivering national-grade security solutions to government, PSUs and critical infrastructure operators through the 'Cyberdome'.

Skoda Auto Volkswagen expands to Sri Lanka

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

In a move reflecting India's growing role as a regional manufacturing hub, Skoda Auto Volkswagen India Private Ltd (SAVWIPL) on Friday announced the launch of the Volkswagen brand in Sri Lanka through local partner Continental Cars and Commercials Ltd.

The company inaugurated a new 3S (sales, service and spares) facility in Colombo as part of its expansion into the island nation.

Skoda Volkswagen India now joins automakers such as Maruti Suzuki, Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Motors and Bajaj Auto that are expanding their export playbooks in the island nation.

The initial lineup entering Sri Lanka includes the Volkswagen Taigun SUV and Virtus sedan, both manufactured at SAVWIPL's Chakan plant near Pune.

EVOLVED PARTNERSHIP

Speaking on the development, Manish Mohan, Senior Director at the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), said the India-Sri Lanka automotive relationship has



Piyush Arora, MD and CEO, Skoda Auto Volkswagen India

steadily evolved beyond a conventional exporter-importer dynamic into a deeper regional manufacturing partnership.

For SAVWIPL, the Sri Lanka entry forms part of a broader export-led strategy.

"Sri Lanka is a market with strong automotive passion and a deep appreciation for quality engineering," said Piyush Arora, Managing Director and CEO, Skoda Auto Volkswagen India Private Ltd. "Volkswagen's entry into the country marks not just the expansion of our footprint, but our long-term strategy to leverage our engineering capabilities to build sustainable growth."

Jan Bures, Executive Director for Sales, Marketing and Digital at SAVWIPL, said South Asia represented a long-term growth opportunity.

VIKAS WSP LIMITED
Regd. Office: Railway Road Swami, Haryana, India, 127046,
Corporate Office: B-86/87, Udyog Vihar RICO, Industrial Area, Sri Ganganagar, Rajasthan, India, 335002
CIN: L24139HR1988PLC030300
Email : csvikaswsp@gmail.com, Website : http://www.vikaswsp.com

NOTICE OF ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
NOTICE is hereby given that the 37th Annual General Meeting of Vikas WSP Limited will be held on Wednesday, 24th June, 2026, at 11:30 A.M. through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") to transact the business as set out in the 37th AGM Notice of the Company.

The Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Government of India ("MCA") vide its general circular no. 03/2025 dated 22.09.2025 general circular no. 9/2024, general circular nos. 20/2020 dated May 5, 2020 and 09/2023 dated September 25, 2023 and other circulars issued in this respect (Circulars) and further Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") vide its Circular dated October 7, 2023 ("SEBI Circular") has provided relaxations from compliance with certain provisions of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (Listing Regulations), accordingly, the companies are allowed to hold Annual General Meeting ("AGM") through VC/OAVM, without the physical presence of Members at a common venue. Thus, in compliance with the Circulars, the AGM of the Company is being held through VC/OAVM. Notice is also hereby given pursuant to Section 91 of the Act and Regulation 42 of the SEBI Listing Regulations, 2015 that the Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from the 18th June 2026 to 24th June 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose 37th Annual General Meeting of the Company for the year 2024-25.

Notice of the AGM along with the Annual Report is being sent through electronic mode to those Members whose email addresses are registered with the Company / Depositories. Members may note that the Notice and Annual Report will also be available on the Company's website <http://www.vikaswsp.com>, website of stock exchange i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and on the MUFG Intime India Private Limited at <https://in.mnps.mufg.com/>.

Members who have not yet registered their e-mail addresses are requested to follow the process mentioned below for registering their e-mail addresses to receive the Notice of the AGM and Integrated Annual Report electronically and to receive Login credentials. Further relevant details along with the prescribed forms are available on the Company's website i.e. <http://www.vikaswsp.com> and the website of the RTA i.e. <https://in.mnps.mufg.com/>.

Pursuant to Master Circular dated 7th May, 2024 & Circular dated 10th June, 2024 issued by SEBI, it is mandatory for all the holders of physical securities to furnish their KYC details including Bank Details. Further details are available on website of the Company and RTA aforementioned.

Details of e-voting are also available on the website of the company and RTA. Further queries relating to e-voting or resolutions proposed to be passed at ensuring AGM may be addressed to the RTA at delhi@in.mnps.mufg.com and/or to the Company on the email as provided above.

Sd/-
Saroj Kumar Senapati,
Company Secretary cum Compliance officer
M.No.- F2898
By order of the Resolution Professional
Mr. Darshan Singh Anand-
Resolution Professional
Place: Delhi
Date: 29-05-2026
IBBI Reg. No.: IBBI/IPA-002/IP-N00326/2017-18/10931

VIKAS WSP LIMITED
Regd Office: Railway Road, Swami, Haryana, India, 127046,
Corporate Office: B-86/87, Udyog Vihar RICO, Industrial Area, Sri Ganganagar, Rajasthan, India, 335002
CIN-L24139HR1988PLC030300 Website: csvikaswsp@gmail.com Website : http://www.vikaswsp.com

EXTRACT OF THE STATEMENT OF STANDALONE AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER & YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Year ended	
		March 31, 2026 (Audited)	December 31, 2025 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2025 (Audited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)	March 31, 2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from operations	8.39	6.22	8.91	25.75	26.94
2	Profit/(Loss) for the period (before exceptional items and tax)	(8,126.21)	(872.48)	(929.05)	(10,752.13)	(3,549.38)
3	Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional items)	(8,126.21)	(872.48)	(929.05)	(10,752.13)	(3,549.38)
4	Net Profit/ Loss for the period after tax (after exceptional items)	(4,071.65)	(872.48)	(40.74)	(6,697.57)	(2,661.07)
5	Total comprehensive income	(4,010.42)	(872.48)	(29.05)	6,636.34	(2,649.38)
6	Equity Share Capital (Face value of Rs.1/-each)	20,440.40	20,440.40	20,440.40	20,440.40	20,440.40
	Reserve excluding revaluation reserves	-	-	-	-	-
7	Earning per share of Rs. 10 each					
(1)	Basic (Rs.)	(1.96)	(0.43)	(0.01)	(3.25)	(1.30)
(2)	Diluted (Rs.)	(1.96)	(0.43)	(0.01)	(3.25)	(1.30)

Notes

- The above Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and Year ended March 31, 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on May 28, 2026. The Independent Auditor's Report of the Statutory Auditors is being filed with the Stock Exchange.
- The above is an extract of the detailed format of Standalone Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31st March, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulation, 2015. The full format of these Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange website (www.bseindia.com)



For and on behalf of Vikas WSP Limited
(Company undergoing CIRP)
Saroj Kumar Senapati,
Company Secretary cum Compliance officer
M.No.- F2898
By order of the Resolution Professional
Mr. Darshan Singh Anand-
Resolution Professional
IBBI Reg. No.: IBBI/IPA-002/IP-N00326/2017-18/10931

OBCL Limited	
(Formerly known as Orissa Bengal Carrier Limited), CIN: L63090CT1994PLC008732 Registered Office: Jwan Bima Marg, Pandri, Raipur (CG) 492001 Corporate Office: A-1, 3rd Floor, CG Elite Complex, Opposite Mandi Gate, Pandri, Raipur (C.G.) 492001 Website: www.obclimited.com , email(s): cs@obclimited.com Tel: +91-771 2281321 0771-4054518	
STATEMENT OF AUDITED (STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED) FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026	
Based on the recommendation of the Audit Committee, the Board of Directors of the Company, at their meeting held on Friday, May 29, 2026, have approved the Audited (Standalone & Consolidated) Financial Results of the Company for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026. Pursuant to Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the aforementioned Financial Results are available on the website of the Company at https://www.obclimited.com/Outcome-of-board-meeting-29-05-2026/ and can also be accessed by scanning the Quick Response (QR) Code:	
Date: 29.05.2026 Place: Raipur	For, OBCL Limited Sd/- Ravi Agrawal Managing Director, DIN:01392652

Kovilpatti Lakshmi Roller Flour Mills Limited
Regd. Office: 75/8, Benares Cape Road, Gangaikondan - 627352
Telephone :+91 462 248 6532 Fax : +91 462 248 6132 E-mail : ho@klrf.in Website : www.klrf.in
CIN : L15314TN1961PLC004674

Statement of Standalone Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and Year ended March 31, 2026 Rs.in Lakhs

S. No	Particulars	Three months ended			Year ended	
		March 31, 2026 (Audited)	December 31, 2025 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2025 (Audited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)	March 31, 2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from operations (net)	10,051.50	10,815.62	10,891.37	41,299.02	42,879.75
2	Net profit/ (loss) for the period (before tax exceptional and/ or extraordinary items)	170.99	103.09	328.83	555.26	154.35
3	Net profit/ (loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional and/ or extraordinary items)	336.57	103.09	328.83	1,015.55	154.35
4	Net profit/ (loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional and/ or extraordinary items)	298.57	71.99	208.01	809.46	115.17
5	Total comprehensive Income for the period [comprising profit / (loss) for the period (after tax) and Other comprehensive income (after tax)]	296.79	75.44	221.18	818.03	128.97
6	Equity share capital	904.15	904.15	904.15	904.15	904.15
7	Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve)				6,551.99	5,779.17
8	Earnings per share (for continuing and discontinuing operations) (of Rs.10/- each)					
a. Basic		3.30	0.80	2.30	8.95	1.27
b. Diluted		3.30	0.80	2.30	8.95	1.27

Notes:

- In accordance with SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations 2015, the above audited financial results for the quarter and year ended March 31 2026, as reviewed and recommended by the audit committee, has been approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on 29th May 2026. The Statutory Auditor has expressed an unmodified opinion on these results.
- Exceptional item represents Profit on Sale of Asset.
- The board of directors have recommended a dividend of Rs.1/- per equity share of face value of Rs.10/-
- On November 21, 2025, the Government of India notified the four Labour Codes - the Code on Wages, 2019, the Industrial Relations Code, 2020, the Code on Social Security, 2020, and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020 - consolidating 29 existing labour laws. The Ministry of Labour & Employment published Central Rules and FAQs to enable assessment of the financial impact due to changes in regulations. The Company has evaluated the impact of the new labour law for employees and assessed that no material incremental liability arises on the same. The Company is in the process of evaluating other possible impact for contract workforce. However, the Company is of the view that impact, if any, is unlikely to be material. The Company continues to monitor the finalisation of Government Rules and clarifications from the Government on other aspects of the Labour Code and would provide appropriate accounting effect based on such developments as needed.
- Consolidated financial statements is not applicable since the company has no subsidiary/associate/joint venture company as on March 31, 2026.
- The figures for the quarter ended March 31, 2026 and March 31,2025 are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of the full financial year and unaudited published figures in respect of the financial results upto the third quarter of the respective financial years.
- Figures for the corresponding quarter / period ended have been regrouped wherever necessary.



Scan the QR code to view the ORR Result in detail

For Kovilpatti Lakshmi Roller Flour Mills Limited
Sharath Jagannathan
Chairman and Managing Director
DIN : 07298941

QUICKLY.

Gold gains on US-Iran ceasefire optimism



Bengaluru: Gold rose for a second session on Friday after news that the US and Iran may have agreed to extend their ceasefire, though prices were headed for a decline as inflation concerns and expectations of higher interest rates weighed. Spot gold was up 0.6 per cent to \$4,519.64 per ounce at 8.52 am EDT (1252 GMT). Prices fell to a 2-month low of \$4,365.76 on Thursday, but closed higher. **REUTERS**

Copper slips after strong month, no news on Iran

London: Copper prices edged lower on Friday as investors waited for more news about a potential deal to extend a ceasefire in Iran and as the dollar firmed. Benchmark three-month copper on the London Metal Exchange slipped 0.7 per cent to \$13,608 a metric tonne by 1425 GMT after gaining 1.3 per cent in the previous session. **REUTERS**

‘Fertilizer available for kharif, problems likely during rabi’

NOTE OF CAUTION. Stop excessive use, diversion for industrial purposes: Fertilizer Secy

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

While India may navigate the availability of fertilizers during the kharif season, it could face problems during the rabi season. Rajat Kumar Mishra, Secretary, Department of Fertilizer, Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers, on Friday said it would be difficult to respond to queries on rabi crop nutrients’ availability now due to the current geopolitical tensions.

He asked the States to stop excessive use of fertilizers and their diversion for industrial purposes. He said per day urea sales were now 80,000 tonnes, almost double from normal.

The blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has disrupted the import of urea, DAP, ammonia and sulphur from West Asia. But China lifting its ban on fertilizer exports two days ago had come as a respite, said experts.

10% HIGHER SALES
Sharing data before the Agriculture Ministers of 17 States at the concluding day



BIZ SO FAR. The Fertilizer Secretary said 50.6 lt of urea had been sold between March 1 and May 25 **VENKATACHALAPATHY C**

of the national kharif conference in New Delhi, Mishra said that 50.6 lakh tonnes (lt) of urea had been sold between March 1 and May 25, nearly 10 per cent higher than 46.01 lt in the year-ago period. Major contributors include Maharashtra, Haryana, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Jammu and Kashmir, Assam, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and West Bengal.

Sales of di-ammonia phosphate (DAP) had surged by over 39 per cent to 12.49 lt since March 1 from 8.98 lt a year ago.

SULPHUR SCARCITY
The Secretary told the States that Morocco, which has 70

per cent of the world’s phosphorus reserves, is unable to produce adequate DAP/TSP due to scarcity of sulphur.

Commenting on some State Agriculture Ministers’ demand to move fertilizer sales through Agristack data, where verified land records of farmers are maintained, Union Agriculture Secretary Atish Chandra said that the Centre would roll out a pilot scheme in two districts each in all the “willing States” this kharif season. Sales would be regulated as per the land record and the crops grown, he said.

Chandra also appealed to the States to take additional grants under the SASCI

scheme by linking and implementing Agristack data in four key areas — fertilizer sales, procurement under MSP, PMFBY and crop production estimate.

STOCK POSITION

Mishra, on the other hand, said that fertilizer sales in nearly 100 districts across the country have exceeded normal requirements. However, owing to proactive government measures, India is currently in a much stronger fertilizer stock position than ever before, he added.

According to him, gas procured through the open tendering process for fertilizer plants has become 70-80 per cent costlier because of the war, while India has so far imported 25 lt of urea at prices 112 per cent higher than pre-war levels. Additionally, India has imported 13.5 lt of DAP at prices nearly 38 per cent above pre-war rates.

India requires around 390 lt of fertilizers during the current kharif season, while existing stocks as on May 25 are around 200 lt, as against 181 lt year-ago.

Key dams’ storage down to 30%

Our Bureau
Chennai

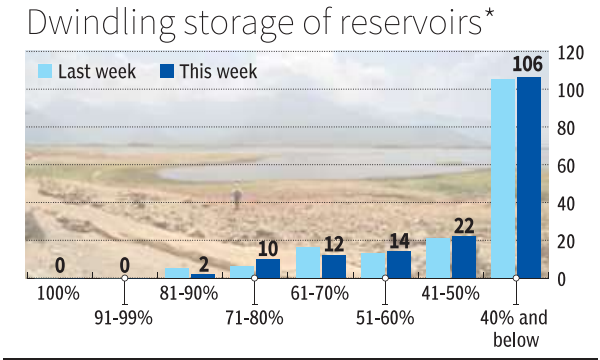
Storage in India’s 166 major reservoirs dropped to 30 per cent of the capacity this week, with 3 of 4 reservoirs being half empty, data from the Central Water Commission (CWC) showed.

The CWC’s weekly status of the major reservoirs showed that storage dropped to 30.67 per cent of the 183.565 billion cubic metres (BCM) capacity to 56.3 BCM. This was higher than the year-ago and normal levels.

Data from the India Meteorological Department (IMD) showed that 29 per cent of the 725 districts experienced deficient or no rainfall between March 1 and May 28. During January-February, at least 70 per cent of the country was rain-deficient. Storage in the east and south dropped below 25 per cent this week, while it was below 40 per cent in the other three regions.

LOWEST IN SOUTH

Storage in the 47 reservoirs in the southern region declined to 22.5 per cent of the 55.288 BCM capacity to 12.459 BCM. Storage in Telangana and Karnataka was precarious at 16 per cent and 16.77 per cent, respectively. The level in Kerala slipped to



Source: Central Water Commission * No of reservoirs

20 per cent, while that in Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu were a tad better at 35 per cent and 33 per cent, respectively.

The 27 reservoirs in the eastern region contained 5.323 BCM, or 24 per cent of the 21.759 BCM capacity. The level in West Bengal’s 2 reservoirs continued to be at 12.5 per cent, while it was down to 21.5 per cent in Odisha.

Recent rain helped improve storage in Assam’s 2 reservoirs to 37 per cent, while the lone reservoirs in Meghalaya and Tripura were filled over 55 per cent and 60 per cent, respectively.

The north was better placed than the others, with the levels in 11 reservoirs clocking 39 per cent of the 19.836 BCM capacity at 7.694 BCM. Storage in Punjab was 59 per cent, while

that in Himachal Pradesh and Rajasthan was 33 per cent and 44 per cent.

MONSOON DELAY

In the west, storage in the 53 reservoirs was 36 per cent or 13.625 BCM of the 38.094 BCM capacity. Goa’s lone reservoir was filled to 31 per cent, while in Maharashtra, the level was 28 per cent. In Gujarat, it was 45 per cent.

In the 28 reservoirs of the central region, storage was 35 per cent of the 48.588 BCM capacity at 17.199 BCM. Chhattisgarh had the best storage of 54 per cent, while the level in Madhya Pradesh was 36 per cent. The level in Uttar Pradesh was 33 per cent and in Uttarakhand, it was 19 per cent.

The storage could come under further stress with the South-West monsoon running into problems.

Chouhan asks States to be prepared for below-normal monsoon

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday asked the States to prepare for the possibility of deficient rainfall and other adverse weather conditions amid the threat of El Niño and the India Meteorological Department’s (IMD) latest forecast indicating a further weakening within the “below-normal” monsoon projection for this year.

The IMD on Friday said the June-September South-West monsoon over the country is likely to be 90 per cent of the long-period average (LPA) of 87 cm, with a model error margin of @4 per cent. In April, the IMD had predicted monsoon at 92 per cent of the LPA.



Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan at a press meet in New Delhi on Friday

“We are monitoring the El Niño phenomenon. There is no certainty at present, but if such a situation develops and there is any delay in monsoon or prolonged dry spell, we are preparing to handle it,” Chouhan told reporters

on the concluding day of the National Agriculture Conference — Kharif Campaign 2026.

El Niño is a drought-bearing climate caused by abnormal warming of surface waters in the eastern Pacific Ocean, which disrupts global weather patterns and generally leads to weaker monsoons and drought-like conditions in India.

Responding to the IMD’s latest forecast, the Minister said, “We are making preparations.”

CONTINGENCY PLANS
According to an official statement, Chouhan urged the States to remain prepared at the district level for deficient rainfall and other difficult conditions.

The Union Agriculture Ministry, he said, is drawing

up contingency plans to deal with any possible situation and has ensured adequate availability of seeds and fertilizers to meet demand during the upcoming kharif (summer-sown) season beginning in June with the onset of the South-West monsoon.

Chouhan said the government currently has adequate stocks available. Against the total requirement of 173 lakh quintals, seed stocks stand at 192 lakh quintals.

He urged the States to lift the available seed stocks and ensure timely distribution to farmers.

BUFFER STOCKS
The Minister said the National Seed Corporation would maintain a buffer stock of 1.74 lakh quintals to address emergency

situations.

Fertilizer stocks currently stand at 200 lakh tonnes against the total kharif requirement of 390 lakh tonnes, he said.

Chouhan asked the States to encourage balanced fertilizer use through the ‘Khet Bachao Abhiyan’ campaign to be conducted from June 1 to June 30.

The Minister said soil health cards should not remain mere documents but must be actively used at the field level to help farmers understand nutrient deficiencies and apply fertilizers appropriately. He also asked every State to prepare its own agricultural roadmap based on agro-climatic conditions, available resources and local potential.

On agricultural credit and Kisan Credit Cards,

Chouhan said timely access to finance is crucial for profitable farming.

AREAS LAGGING

He acknowledged that while some States had performed well in agricultural credit flow, many parts of Eastern and North-Eastern India continue to lag.

He announced that discussions with banks would soon be initiated in coordination with the States to expand access to agricultural credit.

Chouhan informed that 20 State Agriculture Ministers, along with government officials, ICAR scientists and representatives from agricultural universities, are participating in the conference to deliberate on strategies for the forthcoming kharif season.

CCI resumes cotton sale, cuts prices by ₹2,300/candy

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bangalore

The Cotton Corporation of India (CCI) on Friday resumed the sales of the fibre crop procured from the 2025-26 season and also reduced the price by ₹2,300 per candy (356 kg) following an easing trend in global prices.

However, the response from the trade and the mills was muted.

Despite the price cut, the CCI could sell only around 1,200 bales on Friday, of which some 800 bales were purchased by the millers and the rest by the trade, sources said.

This is the second instance of the CCI reducing prices in recent days. Last week, the CCI reduced the price by ₹700 per candy. It



EYE ON PRICE. This is the second instance of the CCI reducing prices. Last week, it cut the price by ₹700 per candy **GETTY IMAGES**

stopped the sales, citing technical reasons, on May 22.

PRICE MISMATCH
“Even at these reduced prices, the sales were meagre as there are less buyers. There is still a mismatch in price. The buyers are seen preferring to wait and watch. Moreover, the prevailing yarn prices are not supporting them,” said Ramanuj Das

Boob, a sourcing agent in Raichur.

The easing trend witnessed in recent days in global prices has prompted the CCI to carry out a price correction. Following the decline in ICE Futures, resellers were seen offering cotton at a discount of about ₹2,000 per candy to the CCI price early this week.

ICE cotton futures, which

had gained around 47 per cent since early February this year, to touch 88 cents per pound on May 11, have eased and are hovering around 76 cents per pound on factors such as improved weather prospects in the US and Brazil and a decline in crude oil prices, among others.

HIKE IN MSP

The CCI, which has procured about 105 lakh bales of 170 kg each, has sold a major chunk of the cotton and stocks with the State-run entity are estimated around 32 lakh bales.

The CCI, which began selling the 2025-26 crop procured at the minimum support price of ₹57,200/candy, reduced prices initially to about ₹54,600 and subsequently increased them to ₹68,600 levels.

Natural diamond ownership among Indian women is on the rise, says De Beers study

Our Bureau
Chennai

The ownership of natural diamond jewellery among Indian women has increased by 4 percentage points from 11 per cent in 2022 to 15 per cent in 2025, states the *De Beers India Diamond Acquisition Study 2025*.

It reflects rising aspiration, accessibility and desirability for natural diamonds in India, the study said.

“The category’s resilience is being driven significantly by younger consumers, with Gen Z and Millennials now accounting for 86 per cent of India’s total natural diamond market value, with



consumers spending an average of ₹1,98,000 per piece,” it said.

GROWTH AT 12% CAGR

The market is further projected to grow at 12 per cent CAGR, reaching ₹1.52 lakh crore by 2030. India’s growing affinity towards diamonds is also reflected in

evolving consumer preferences.

A press release from the Natural Diamonds Council (NDC) quoted a Deloitte study, which found that diamonds are second only to gold in jewellery material preference among 20-25-year-olds, with 58 per cent of respondents in the age group choosing diamonds.

NDC said leading jewellery retailers had reported that the natural diamond category was consistently outpacing overall market growth. Saurabh Gadgil, Chairman of jewellers PN Gadgil, said the company’s diamond segment grew at 61 per cent year-on-year, significantly higher than their gold segment.

FESTIVE SALES

Malabar Gold & Diamonds Chairman MP Ahammed said diamond studded jewellery sales were up 45 per cent during Akshaya Tritiya.

Richa Singh, Managing Director, Natural Diamond Council, said, “In just three years, natural diamond ownership among Indian women has grown from 11 per cent to 15 per cent.” The natural diamond’s place in India is no longer a matter of sentiment. It is a matter of record.

She said as India’s personal disposable income is projected to grow by 11 per cent annually, the natural diamond is uniquely positioned to remain the definitive standard for luxury.

Kerala to get Women Farmers Consortium

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

Kerala will prepare a comprehensive plan to identify both existing and potential women farmers in every panchayat in a bid to boost the State’s agricultural sector.

The initiative aims to integrate women across the entire agricultural value chain — from production to processing and distribution — through a structured programme, Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar said in his policy address to the 16th Legislative Assembly.

A Women Farmers Consortium will be launched this year to mobilise individual women farmers as well as small and large collectives in the sector.



Special schemes will be introduced to support women in activities such as paddy cultivation, vegetable and fruit farming, pulses, tuber crops, mushroom cultivation and beekeeping.

FAIR PRICES

The Governor said agriculture remains top priority for the government, even as farmers face multiple challenges, including rising input costs, price fluctuations, cli-

mate uncertainty, wildlife attacks, fragmented landholdings, poor irrigation coverage, land fallowing, low mechanisation and climate-induced disasters.

Measures will be taken to improve farm incomes, strengthen procurement systems, revise floor prices and ensure timely and fair prices for crops, such as paddy, coconut, rubber and others.

Special attention will be given to farmers in high-range and wildlife-affected areas.

FARMER INCOMES

The government will also promote modern technology to enhance productivity, reduce costs and encourage mechanisation and secondary agriculture.

Golden Tips Tea eyes expansion in Bengal general trade in 6 months

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

Golden Tips Tea, one of India’s oldest tea brands, plans to enter the general trade across West Bengal within six months.

The company currently has 15 own stores and 16 franchise stores — in West Bengal and Sikkim. Apart from online sales, its premium Darjeeling teas are currently available at a few lifestyle stores in some metro cities, except Kolkata.

“We plan to start general trade within six months. The first phase will be across

West Bengal. If we have distributors, we could later enter Assam, Bihar and Odisha, where people know our brand very well,” Managing Director Madhav Sarda told *businessline*.

PAN-INDIA PRESENCE

The company is eyeing a franchise model to expand pan India. “In the franchise model, we don’t actually make any investment. The entire investment is made by the respective firms,” Sarda said. “In the next three years, we want to open around 100 outlets across the country.”

It exports its teas to China, Russia and Japan.

Kochi tea auctions bear the brunt of renewed West Asia conflict

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

Re-escalating tensions in West Asia seem to be impacting Kochi’s tea auction market, with overseas buyers turning cautious in their purchases. The weekly intake of orthodox teas has declined, reflected in the higher percentage of unsold quantities in Sale 22.

Traders also reported delays in payments from overseas buyers, prompting some exporters to temporarily pause shipments.

Auctioneers Forbes, Ewart & Figgis said the orthodox tea market remained irregular and lower by ₹5 to ₹10.

While buyers from West Asia stayed active, support from CIS countries was only moderate. The quantity offered stood at 2,11,525 kg, with sales percentage of 82.

WEAK SENTIMENT

Anil George, President of the Tea Trade Association of Cochín, said the sentiment for CTC teas is also expected to remain weak. The trade continues to be affected by the LPG crisis and reduced operations of tea shops in several markets.

However, dust tea prices in Kochi are likely to improve towards the end of June in view of Onam.

The market is expected to stabilise after the second

week of June, with improved enquiries likely for better liquoring teas.

WEATHER CONCERNS

Higher North India second flush prices may lend support to quality South Indian teas. While crop levels may improve over the next few weeks following the recent rain, sustaining higher production levels remains uncertain due to erratic weather conditions, he said.

The auctioneers said the CTC dust market was lower by ₹1 to ₹2 and all blenders together absorbed 72 per cent of the offered quantity of 6,07,012 kg. The unsold quantity was also on the higher side.

QUICKLY.

Kurve Sachin is chief of Chennai Port Authority



Chennai: Kurve Sachin Shardchandra has taken charge as Chairperson of the Chennai Port Authority (ChPA). He succeeds Sunil Paliwal, who is now serving as Chairman of the Inland Waterways Authority of India. **OUR BUREAU**

PM Surya Ghar lights up 40 lakh households

New Delhi: A total of 40 lakh households have been solarised under the government's PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi said on Friday. The scheme is turning citizens from power consumers to power producers, the MNRE Minister said in a post on X. Launched in February 2024, the scheme aims to install rooftop solar systems in one crore households by March 2027. **PTI**

SC slams Centre, says NEET paper leak has left students, families traumatised

SEEKS ACCOUNTABILITY. HR Ministry to file affidavit on how it will address lack of ‘intellectual wherewithal’

Krishnadas Rajagopal
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday said the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak had left students and entire families traumatised to find that years of hard work and emotional investment had gone waste even as the Centre said Prime Minister Narendra Modi is “personally monitoring” the situation.

A Bench, headed by Justice PS Narasimha, asked why the National Testing Agency (NTA), which holds the NEET-UG exam, repeats its mistakes when the Union Public Services Commission had so far made none.

The court zeroed in on the problem of *ad-hocism* in the NTA, and the lack of “institutional memory and framework”.

The court directed the Ministry of Human Resource and Development (MHRD) to file an affidavit explaining

the measures it intends to take to tackle the lack of “physical and intellectual wherewithal” and improve institutional capacity within the NTA.

The NTA maintained that the cancellation of NEET-UG 2026 and the transfer of the investigation to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) by itself reflected the seriousness with which examination integrity was treated by both the NTA and the Union government.

The cancellation of NEET-UG 2026, conducted on May 3, had left around 23 lakh candidates facing uncertainty over their academic future. But the court also struck an optimistic tone, saying the situation was “not beyond us”.

“We have some of the best officers heading these institutions. But they get transferred and take their experience and know-how with them. The knowledge is not percolated to the next group



EXAM REFORMS. Among the key changes, the agency said it had introduced multiple sets of question papers, with one set retained as a backup

of people who are going to run the institution. It is not the individual who should have the memory, the institution must retain its memories, experiences and learn from them,” Justice Narasimha observed.

The court asked the Ministry to specify the steps taken to retain specialised personnel, preserve institutional memory and ensure a plurality of expertise in the conduct of NEET examinations.

“The endeavour is to ensure that NTA has the physical and intellectual wherewithal to ensure no incidents like in the NEET-UG 2024 and 2026 exams occur again,” Justice Narasimha said. The apex court has scheduled the next hearing on the matter in the second week of July.

COMPUTER TEST
“The real problem will not stop till there is actual accountability. Not in terms of

so and so will be liable, it will be effective when we know which individual shoulders the responsibility. Unless you identify the specific duty-bearers, it will be difficult,” Justice Narasimha observed.

In its affidavit, NTA said it will conduct NEET-UG in the computer-based test (CBT) mode from next year instead of the pen and paper mode after consulting the Centre.

A high-level committee of experts has recommended the transition.

MULTIPLE SETS
Among the key changes, the agency said it had introduced multiple sets of question papers, with one set retained as backup.

A designated senior officer will oversee the entire printing process, and the use of electronic devices has now been prohibited. All CCTV recordings would also be preserved.

For DKS, the hard part will be balancing welfare, caste equation, infra

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

While DK Shivakumar has finally wangled for himself the chief ministership of Karnataka, the tougher challenge begins now. With barely over 20 months left before the next Assembly election, the incoming CM inherits a politically sensitive and fiscally stretched State, alongside mounting pressure to deliver on governance and infrastructure.

The Congress government’s welfare guarantees

have significantly stretched the State’s finances, with Karnataka borrowing nearly ₹20,000 crore additionally every year to sustain the schemes. As per a Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report, the State borrowed ₹63,000 crore in 2023-24 to fund guarantee schemes and bridge the financial gaps they created, ₹37,000 crore higher than the previous year’s net debt of ₹26,000 crore.

The report also noted that nearly ₹5,299 crore earmarked for capital expenditure on infrastructure was di-



DK Shivakumar

verted towards guarantee schemes during the year.

As of March 2026, Karnataka’s per capita debt burden has surged to ₹1.12 lakh.

Another immediate political challenge will be the contentious caste census report released before Siddaramaiah stepped down. Shivakumar had earlier opposed the survey.

Karnataka conducted two caste surveys in the last nine years, both under Siddaramaiah’s leadership.

FIRST SURVEY
The first survey, commissioned in 2015 under the H Kantharaj Commission, was completed by 2018 but remained politically sensitive for years. The latest report is

expected to intensify caste equations ahead of the election cycle and could trigger friction among the dominant and backward communities.

CONTINUED INFLUENCE
Despite stepping down as Chief Minister, Siddaramaiah remains a powerful force within the Congress. His decision to reject a Rajya Sabha berth and remain active in Karnataka politics raises questions over how much influence he will continue to exert in the day-to-day functioning of the government.

Shivakumar will also have to navigate demands for Deputy Chief Minister representation from different caste and ideological blocs, including AHINDA factions. Known to oppose power-sharing arrangements, Shivakumar could face internal friction if competing camps push for greater representation in the new Cabinet.

Political analyst Harish Ramaswamy said Shivakumar’s biggest test would be balancing governance, caste equations, cabinet formation and fiscal management simultaneously.

In Governor’s address in Assembly, Kerala outlines push for industrial growth, investment reforms

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

Kerala Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar on Friday outlined the UDF government’s vision to transform the State into a globally competitive, innovation-driven and sustainable industrial economy in his policy address to the 16th Legislative Assembly.

In his hour-long speech, the Governor said the government aims to strengthen infrastructure, accelerate investments and create high-quality employment opportunities.

MAJOR INITIATIVES
He highlighted major initiatives, including port-led logistics and industrial development, expansion of industrial parks and sector-focused industrial ecosystems to position Kerala as the preferred destination for



POLICY OUTLINE. Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar delivering the customary address at the Assembly in Thiruvananthapuram on Friday **ANI**

manufacturing, logistics, technology, life sciences and global capability centres.

The government will introduce progressive reforms to boost investor confidence, including formalising the Investment Promotion Board for high-value projects, modernising K-SWIFT into an integrated digital single-window clearance platform and empowering the Kerala State Single Window Clearance Board for faster, time-bound approvals and project facilitation. Along with support for

MSMEs and traditional sectors such as coir, handloom, plantations and food processing, the government plans focused promotion of emerging sectors, including artificial intelligence, biotechnology, medical devices, green energy, electronics and space technology to ensure inclusive industrialisation.

LAND BANK
Stressing that industrial land availability is critical for attracting investments, he said

the government will prioritise the creation of a land bank through Special Purpose Vehicles using market borrowing and private fundraising.

LEGAL AID
On elderly care, the address highlighted plans to make all cities in Kerala elderly-friendly.

“Care Cabins” will function at Collectorates as support centres offering legal aid, healthcare and protection services for senior citizens.

In higher education, the government proposed setting up an Academic Syndicate as an apex body for administrative and governance matters.

Special emphasis will be placed on building globally competitive higher education institutions within the State to reduce academic migration and retain talented students.

West Bengal halves threshold limit for e-way bills to ₹50,000 to encourage compliance

Mithun Dasgupta
Shishir Sinha
Kolkata/New Delhi

The West Bengal government has brought down the threshold limit for generation of e-way bills for intra-State movement of goods to ₹50,000 from the current ₹1 lakh to strengthen compliance and prevent tax evasion.

This move by the new BJP government is aimed at generating more tax revenues. However, some industry insiders feel that it would increase workloads for a large number of small traders.

EFFECTIVE JUNE 1
The Directorate of Commercial Taxes, has issued a notification, stating that “an e-way bill is required to be generated in respect of movement of goods originating and terminating within the State having consign-



ment value exceeding ₹50,000.”

This notification on the revised threshold level of consignment value for generation of an e-way bill, other than job work, will come into force from June 1.

“The decision to reduce the intra-state e-way bill threshold from ₹1 lakh to ₹50,000 is for strengthening

compliance, and preventing undervaluation and evasion of taxes. It is also a way towards simplification of tax structures,” a senior government official told *businessline*.

According to Sandip Chharia, an advocate and a senior sales tax consultant, the reduction in the threshold level of consignment value for generation of an e-way bill would reduce evasion of taxes to a great extent.

SMALL TRADER HIT
“e-way bill is a mechanism to bring transactions within a State into the net of taxation. In West Bengal, there have been several instances of undervaluation and evasion of taxes. After the reduction in the threshold level for generation of an e-way bill, evasion of taxes is expected to come down to a great extent. It will help the government increase tax revenues collection,” Chharia said.

Sushil Poddar, president of the Confederation of West Bengal Trade Association (CWBT), said the setting the threshold limit for e-way bills for intra-state movement of goods at ₹50,000 would hit the State’s small traders hard.

“It will increase the workload and compliance cost to a large number of small traders. Therefore, we have written a letter to the government requesting the threshold limit should be at least from ₹1 lakh,” Poddar told *businessline*.

THRESHOLD LIMIT
Notably, Maharashtra, Delhi, Tamil Nadu, Punjab, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar and Jharkhand, among others, have the threshold limit at ₹1 lakh while Gujarat, Haryana, Karnataka, Kerala, Telangana, Assam, Tripura, Uttar Pradesh and Himachal Pradesh, among others, have the threshold limit of ₹50,000.

TN reshuffle: Kulkarni named Prohibition and Excise Commissioner

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Tamil Nadu government on Friday announced a major reshuffle of over 30 IAS officers.

KEY APPOINTMENTS

Among the key appointments, Pooja Kulkarni, CEO, Tamil Nadu Infrastructure Development Board is posted as Commissioner, Prohibition and Excise. MS Prasath, Collector, Kallakurichi District, has been transferred and posted as Deputy Secretary to Government, Finance Department. Mangat Ram Sharma has been posted to the Tamil Nadu Power Finance and Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd, while J



Jayakanthan has been placed at the disposal of Poampuhar Shipping Corporation Ltd.

E Saravanelraj has been appointed to Tamil Nadu Minerals Ltd, and PN Sridhar to the Tamil Nadu Green Energy Corporation.

The government also posted SP Karthikaa to the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority and Simranjeet Singh Kahlon to the Chennai Rivers Restoration Trust.

Intel, Odisha sign \$3.3 billion semicon substrate production deal

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Chip maker Intel Corporation has signed a pact with the Odisha government and 3DGS to bring semiconductor substrate manufacturing technology to India, an official said on Friday.

Union Minister of Electronics and IT Ashwini Vaishnaw, along with Chief Minister of Odisha Mohan Charan Majhi, Intel CEO Lip-Bu Tan, and other dignitaries, witnessed the signing of the MoU, the statement said. “Congratulations to Odisha, Intel and 3DGS on signing an MoU to bring substrate manufacturing technology to India.”

This will further advance the semiconductor ecosystem in India,” Vaishnaw said. A semiconductor substrate is

The project will come up in Bhubaneswar-Khurda region and is expected to generate over 1,800 skilled jobs

the layer of chip on which circuits are built.

FIRST PROJECT

The project, with an estimated investment of about \$3.3 billion, will come up in the Bhubaneswar-Khurda region and is the first with the engagement of computer chip major Intel. To be implemented over five-six years, it is expected to generate more than 1,800 direct high-skilled jobs.

“It will make advanced packaging glass core sub-

strates, high-density interconnect substrates and associated semiconductor technologies, with Intel supporting technology know-how and process expertise. It is expected to contribute to capability development, ecosystem growth and export-oriented manufacturing in India,” a statement said.

Vaishnaw said the entry of firms like Applied Materials Inc, Lam Research, Tokyo Electron Ltd, Merck Electronics, and signing of the MoU between Tata Electronics and Dutch multinational ASML — is a recognition of the government’s efforts in the semiconductor sector and the trust the industry places in India.

India is now gearing up for the launch of India Semicon Mission 2.0, which is expected to incentivise the entire chip manufacturing ecosystem.

Maersk to launch FI2 India-China service

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

AP Moller-Maersk has launched a dedicated ocean service connecting Far East Asia to the Indian subcontinent, with the first sailing expected to depart Shanghai on June 4.

The service, FI2, has been introduced following customer demand for additional capacity on the China-India trade route.

It will provide Indian importers and exporters with a quicker, reliable, high-frequency connection to key manufacturing and sourcing hubs across north west India, the Danish shipping major said.

WEEKLY RUN

The weekly service will be operated with a fleet of six vessels with a nominal capacity of 4,500 TEU.

The port rotation will be



Shanghai-Ningbo-Nansha-Tanjung Pelepas-Nhava Sheva-Pipavav-Port Qasim.

QUICKER SERVICE

A company official said the service will also be quicker by 5-6 days than the existing FI3 service.

The FI3 service, connecting Jawaharlal Nehru, Pipavav, Karachi, Mundra, Colombo, Singapore, Qingdao, Xingang and Busan ports, takes 30 days.

Maersk said that a defining feature of the FI2 service is its call at Pipavav in Gu-

jarat. Pipavav serves as a gateway to the Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC) rail network, enabling Maersk to offer customers a seamless, integrated logistics solution beyond the port gate.

Through DFC rail connectivity, cargo arriving at Pipavav can be efficiently transported inland to the National Capital Region (NCR), including Delhi, Gurugram, Noida, and the surrounding industrial belts.

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QUICKLY.

Common landing portal for unclaimed assets

New Delhi: The Finance Ministry on Friday launched a single unified online platform for citizens to search and trace unclaimed bank deposits, insurance claims, shares and mutual funds. The initiative is expected to enhance public awareness, improve ease of access to information and contribute to the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047 through greater financial empowerment, inclusion and trust in the financial system, the finance ministry said in a statement. The portal has been launched in collaboration with PSB Alliance to facilitate easier access to information relating to unclaimed financial assets. “The portal, <https://www.unclaimedassetsportal.in>, serves as a unified platform providing access to search facilities relating to unclaimed bank deposits, insurance claims, shares, dividends and mutual funds available across the financial ecosystem,” it said. Department of Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju launched the unified platform during the review meeting of public sector banks. **PTI**

GST ruling by SC leaves real money gaming firms fighting for survival

SHAKEUP IN SECTOR. Retrospective GST demands raise insolvency risks, forcing firms to rethink operations

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The Supreme Court’s decision upholding the 28 per cent goods and services tax (GST) levy on real-money gaming platforms, including its retrospective application, has intensified fears of insolvency and shutdown across India’s online gaming industry, with companies now reassessing business models and legal options. The ruling revives tax demands worth nearly ₹92,000 crore on past transactions and significantly weakens the industry’s long-standing challenge to the tax framework. Companies such as Dream11 parent Dream Sports, Gameskraft, Mobile Premier League and Jungle Games are expected to face heightened financial pressure as pending show-cause notices move towards adju-



GAME OVER. The SC ruling marks the end of the hyper-growth era for real-money online gaming in India

dication. In its judgment on Wednesday, the top court held that online gaming companies are liable to pay 28 per cent GST on the full face value of bets placed on their platforms, instead of the platform fee or commission earned by them. The court also agreed with the government’s argument that the 2023 GST amendments were clarificatory in nature, effectively validating retrospective tax demands. “The demands now far ex-

ceed the cash reserves and operating capacity of several companies in the sector, making survival and business continuity a serious challenge,” said a senior investor in an online gaming company, requesting anonymity.

CASH BALANCE According to filings, Dream11 had a cash balance of ₹557.7 crore at the end of FY25, while Gameskraft held about ₹252 crore. However, the two companies have re-

portedly received GST notices exceeding ₹25,000 crore and ₹21,000 crore, respectively. “The Supreme Court’s ruling marks the end of the hyper-growth era for real-money online gaming in India,” said Rajat Bose, Partner-Indirect Tax at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co. “By backing the 28 per cent GST on full face value and validating its retrospective enforcement, the apex court has effectively triggered a legal and economic restructuring of the entire digital entertainment ecosystem.” Bose added that the industry’s core grievance has always been the valuation rule, under which platforms are taxed on the entire contest entry amount rather than the commission they retain. **ALTERNATIVE REVENUE** Industry executives said the ruling could accelerate a shift towards alternative revenue models such as ad-supported gaming, esports and overseas expansion. Dream Sports recast itself as a “second-screen sports platform” in December and recently launched a stock-broking platform, Dream-Street. Winzo, meanwhile, expanded into the US market and introduced the short-video feature ZO TV after the blanket ban on real-money gaming last year. Abhay Sharma, Partner and Head of Tax Practice at Bombay Law Chambers, said the judgment fundamentally alters the economics of the sector. “All online gaming operators are now held to be suppliers of actionable claims, liable to pay 28 per cent GST on the full value of bets. These demands, including interest and penalties, may be unsustainable for many in the industry,” he said.

Airlines seek digital platform for Ebola self declaration

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Airlines have asked the government to quickly roll out a digital platform for the submission of passenger self-declaration forms as a part of the Ebola virus containment measures. This would improve compliance and save printing expenses, airline executives told the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) during review meetings this week. On May 22, the DGCA issued an order asking airlines offering direct and indirect connectivity to Uganda and the Democratic Republic of Congo to distribute self-declaration forms to passengers. While the May 22 order has not been amended, instructions were issued on Monday to all international airlines operating in Delhi to distribute these forms. Subsequently, similar instructions have been issued at a few other airports. Alongside distributing forms, the crew have also been asked to make announcements prior to arrival in India. On their part, airlines have asked the regulator to introduce a digital platform like the Air Suvidha app that was used during the Covid-19 pandemic. A suggestion was also made to incorporate the Ebola self-declaration form in the immigration department’s online platform.

HEALTH EMERGENCY “We realise the Ebola outbreak in Africa is a public health emergency and support the Indian government’s initiative. However, more time should have been provided to airlines for preparing themselves,” an executive pointed out. Some airlines are advising passengers to scan a QR code to access the self-declaration form. Airports, too, are gearing up. Chennai airport has set up dedicated isolation rooms and also carried out a mock drill to assess emergency response readiness and inter-agency co-ordination. The Civil Aviation Ministry did not respond to a query.

‘India sends first tranche of medical supplies to Africa’

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

India has sent its first tranche of medical supplies to the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention (Africa CDC) amid the outbreak of Ebola in parts of the continent, said the Ministry of External Affairs on Friday. On May 17, the WHO declared the Ebola outbreak in Congo and Uganda a public health emergency of international concern. At his weekly media briefing, External Affairs Ministry’s spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal was asked if India had sent any medical aid to Africa in the

wake of the outbreak. “On your question, about the help that we have sent, we have sent medical supplies to CDC Africa. This was handed over by our High Commissioner in Uganda to CDC office there. We look forward to further helping, in whatever manner we can, with the countries and with the CDC,” he said. African CDC is a specialised technical institution of the African Union set up in 2016 to support public health initiatives of member states and strengthen the capacity of their public health institutions to detect, prevent, control and respond quickly to disease threats.

Experts assess Ebola treatments; vax candidates from Oxford/SII in focus

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Advisory groups convened by the World Health Organization have considered promising candidates for prioritisation and evaluation in clinical trials, including a candidate vaccine ChAdOx1 Bundibugyo being developed by Oxford University/the Serum Institute of India. The vaccine could potentially become available within two to three months for efficacy assessment through a clinical trial, said the WHO. Following the Ebola outbreak, the WHO said it was working with the govern-

ments of the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) and Uganda — ground zero of the outbreak — to facilitate the research evaluation of the identified products. At present, there are no licensed therapeutics or vaccines approved for the prevention and treatment of the Bundibugyo virus disease (BVD). For treatment, the experts recommended three candidate therapeutics for evaluation through clinical trials among the confirmed BVD cases. They include the monoclonal antibodies MBP134 and Maftivimab (from US company Regeneron) as well as anti-

viral remdesivir (US company Gilead). Combination therapy using a monoclonal antibody and remdesivir is also recommended for evaluation, said the WHO. **PRIORITY CANDIDATE** For post-exposure prophylaxis among contacts of confirmed and probable cases, the oral antiviral obeldesivir (Gilead) was identified as a priority candidate, although experts noted that this approach depends on effective contact tracing, which remains operationally challenging in some affected areas of the DRC, said the WHO. “Research on post-exposure prophylaxis involves giving tablets of obeldesivir



The vaccine could potentially become available within two to three months for efficacy assessment, the WHO said. Also on the radar is ChAdOx1 Bundibugyo, being developed by Oxford University/the Serum Institute of India, with the potential to become available within three months for efficacy assessment through a clinical trial, it said. “However, additional animal data are still required to support and confirm further prioritization,” said the WHO, adding that a single-dose vaccine to contacts of cases to evaluate whether this prevents them from developing Ebola disease,” it said. The most promising candidate vaccine was the single-dose rVSV

Bundibugyo vaccine, being developed by the International AIDS Vaccine Initiative (IAVI). Its development would take about seven to nine months, said the WHO, before it is ready to be assessed through a clinical trial for its ability to prevent BDV. Also on the radar is ChAdOx1 Bundibugyo, being developed by Oxford University/the Serum Institute of India, with the potential to become available within three months for efficacy assessment through a clinical trial, it said. “However, additional animal data are still required to support and confirm further prioritization,” said the WHO, adding that a single-dose vaccine approach of this candidate could be suitable for contacts of Ebola cases, whereas a two-dose strategy might be considered for high-risk but unexposed populations such as health-care workers and frontline responders, it said. Experts also looked at Ervebo (Merck MSD), the only licensed Ebola vaccine. It is approved for use during outbreaks caused by the most common Ebola virus in Africa, from the Orthobolavirus family, said the WHO. Ervebo is not licensed for prevention of BVD and evidence on cross-protection to other Ebola virus species remains limited and inconclusive, the UN health agency said.



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